

CocoaMojo

Writing native macOS applications in Mojo, on a compiler that reads the SDK.

CocoaMojo is the Cocoa layer of [MojoCocoa](#), an unofficial fork of Mojo frozen at one commit. It is two things at once: a small standard-library package, `std.objc`, and a compiler hook, `cocoakb`, that answers questions about macOS *while your program is being compiled*.

The result is that a Cocoa binding states a name and the compiler supplies everything else. A selector typo is a compile error. A struct that has drifted from the SDK fails to build. An argument in the wrong register file is a compile error rather than a corrupted call.

```
comptime assert sizeof[CGRect]() == cocoakb_struct_size["CGRect"]()

var s = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSString", "stringWithUTF8String:", is_class=True
](cls.as_object(), text.as_c_string_slice())
```

These documents

Document	What it is
Programmer's Guide	Read this first. Progressive, worked examples, ending in a complete windowed application.
Reference Manual	Look things up here. The frozen language dialect, every <code>std.objc</code> entry point, every <code>cocoakb</code> query, and every diagnostic.

A warning about versions

Mojo has been changing quickly, and most writing about it — including parts of its own published documentation — describes a language this compiler does not accept. `@parameter if` and `@parameter for` have given way to `comptime if` and `comptime for`, and `alias` is deprecated in favour of `comptime`.

This fork has also stopped following upstream's declaration model and named itself **cocoa-mojo**. Two keywords upstream removed are back, with new and narrower meanings: **fn** is now the foreign-callable function — thin, non-raising, C ABI, exactly the Objective-C `IMP` contract — and **let** is an immutable, scope-bound binding. Neither means what it meant in older Mojo, and neither means what upstream would mean by it.

Everything in these documents was checked against the source tree of this frozen compiler, not against published documentation. Where the two disagree, the compiler is right and the documentation is stale. The [Language reference](#) lists the differences explicitly, because they are the single largest source of code that looks correct and will not build.

The state of the port

The Cocoa layer described here works and is verified: nine of nine verification spikes pass, and the example applications build and run.

The GPU layer of the same fork does not yet run end to end, and nothing in these documents depends on it. Where a GPU topic is unavoidable — the Mandelbrot example draws through a `CAMetalLayer` — it is marked.

Conventions

Code shown in these documents is either taken directly from the fork's standard library and verification spikes, or is reduced from them. Where a listing is abbreviated, an ellipsis comment says so.

The database is a build input, not a runtime dependency. A compiled CocoaMojo program has no dependency on `cocoa.sqlite`. By the time code is generated, every query has already collapsed to a constant.

CocoaMojo Programmer's Guide

This guide teaches CocoaMojo in the order you meet it: get a compiler running, learn what the language actually is at this frozen version, send your first message to Cocoa, get memory right, let Cocoa call back into your code, and finally assemble a real windowed application.

Read it in order the first time. Each chapter assumes the one before it.

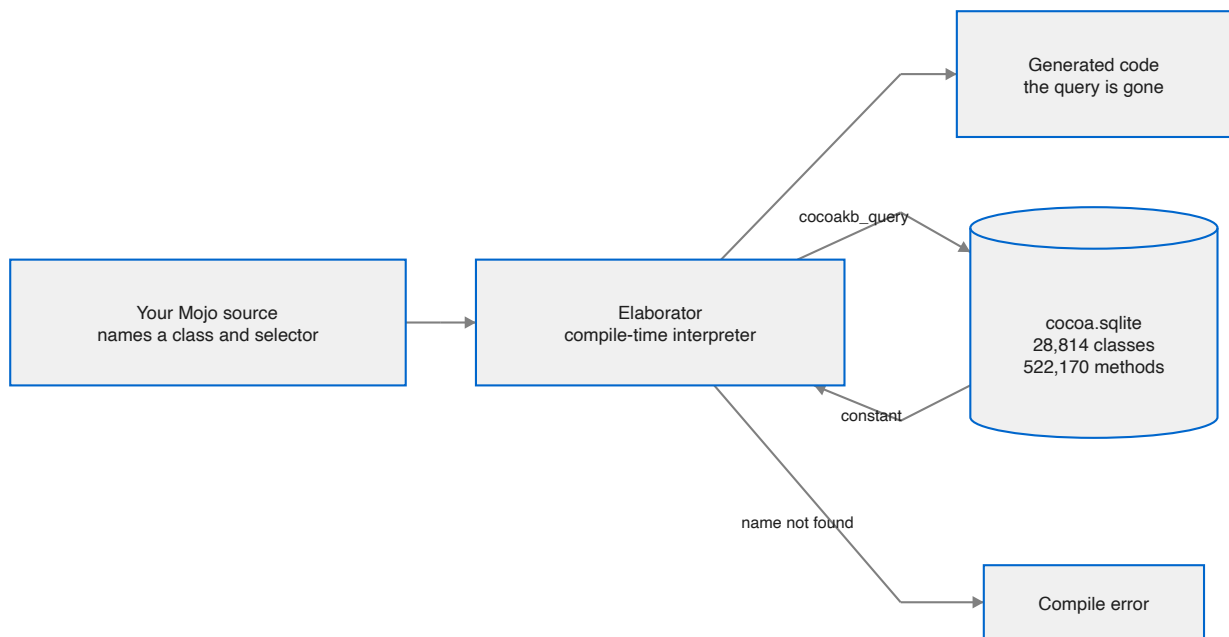
Chapter	What you will be able to do
1. Getting started	Build the compiler, build the SDK database, compile and run a program
2. The language, as it is now	Write code this compiler accepts, and recognise the constructs it rejects
3. Calling Cocoa	Look up classes, send messages, pass arguments, get results back
4. Ownership and memory	Hold Cocoa objects without leaking and without over-releasing
5. Letting Cocoa call you	Define Objective-C classes at runtime whose methods are Mojo functions
6. A complete application	Put a window on screen, handle events, and drive a run loop
7. Concurrency and blocks	Dispatch work across GCD queues, and call block-only Cocoa APIs
8. A demo, walked through	Read a complete 225-line windowed program line by line

When you want to look something up rather than learn it, use the [Reference Manual](#).

What makes this different from a binding layer

Most language bridges to Cocoa work by generating declarations: a tool reads the SDK once, emits a large body of source, and from that moment the generated code and the real SDK drift apart silently.

CocoaMojo does not generate anything. The compiler holds an open connection to a database describing macOS, and resolves each fact at the point of use during elaboration.



Two consequences follow, and they are the reason the whole design exists.

The first is that **a wrong name cannot survive to run time**. There is no generated stub to be out of date, so a selector the SDK does not have has nowhere to hide.

The second is that **the compiled program has no dependency on the database**. By the time code is generated, every query has collapsed to a constant. The database is a build input in exactly the way a header file is.

1. Getting started

What you need

Requirement	Why
Apple Silicon Mac	The fork targets arm64 Darwin and hardcodes it deliberately
macOS 15 or later	The metadata is built from the live Objective-C runtime on your machine
Xcode 16 or later	Supplies the SDK and, if you go near the GPU, the AIR toolchain
A checkout of MojoCocoa	The compiler and standard library
A checkout of CocoaBaseMCP	Builds cocoa.sqlite

The two checkouts are expected to sit beside each other. Everything below assumes that layout; if yours differs, one environment variable fixes it.

Build the SDK database

The database is built from *your* machine — the live Objective-C runtime plus BridgeSupport — not downloaded. It takes about twelve seconds.

```
python3 ../CocoaBaseMCP/build.py
```

You get roughly 236 MB describing 28,814 classes and 522,170 methods.

Rebuild it after any macOS update. If you do not, the compiler will happily keep using the old one, and `cocoakb_db_hash()` is how you notice: it returns the SHA-256 of the database a given compilation consulted, so a binary can record exactly which revision it was built against.

Build the compiler

```
./bazelw build --config=build-mojo //KGEN:mojo
```

This is a long build the first time. Afterwards, only toolchain or sysroot changes force a full rebuild — ordinary source changes rebuild KGEN alone, in seconds rather than the better part of an hour.

The compiler lands at `bazel-bin/KGEN/tools/mojo/mojo-full`.

Point the compiler at the database

```
export MODULAR_MOJO_MAX_COCOAKB_PATH="$PWD/../CocoaBaseMCP/cocoa.sqlite"
```

`local.bazelrc` sets this for Bazel-driven builds. Export it yourself when invoking the compiler directly.

Run a program

There is a wrinkle worth knowing before it wastes your afternoon. The raw `mojo-full` binary cannot locate `std.mojoc` on its own. Run Mojo through the Bazel wrapper, which supplies the standard-library import paths:

```
./bazelw run //KGEN:mojo -- run /absolute/path/to/program.mojo
```

Note the **absolute** path. Bazel runs the wrapper in its own working directory, so a relative path will not resolve the way you expect.

Your first program

Save this as `hello_cocoa.mojo`:

```
from std.objc import ObjCClass, ObjCObject, msg_send, autoreleasepool
from std.ffi import c_char
from std.memory import OpaquePointer

def main():
    with autoreleasepool():
        var cls = ObjCClass.lookup["NSString"]()
        var text = String("Hello from Cocoa, via Mojo")

        var s = msg_send[
            ObjCObject, "NSString", "stringWithUTF8String:", is_class=True
        ](cls.as_object(), text.as_c_string_slice())

        var n = msg_send[Int, "NSString", "length"](s)
        print("length:", n)

        var back = msg_send[
            OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin], "NSString", "UTF8String"
        ](s)
        print("round trip:", String(unsafe_from_utf8_ptr=back.bitcast[c_char]()))
```

Run it, and you should see:

```
length: 26
round trip: Hello from Cocoa, via Mojo
```

Nothing in that program named a dispatch function, a type encoding, or a selector address. Those all came from the database while the program was being compiled.

Prove the checking is real

The interesting half of the verification suite is the half that must *fail*. Change `"length"` to `"lenght"` and compile again. You do not get a runtime crash or a silently wrong answer; you get a compile error

naming the selector.

The fork ships this as a test:

```
./spikes/run-cocoa-checks.sh
```

It runs twelve spikes that must compile and run, and four that must be **rejected at compile time** — sixteen checks in all. A run in which the must-fail spikes quietly succeed is a failed run, because the design's entire claim is that unknown names cannot reach code generation.

The four must-fail checks are worth knowing individually, because each pins one guarantee: an unknown metadata name (`must_fail.mojo`), a wrong argument count (`must_fail_argcount.mojo`), a raising `fn` (`must_fail_fn_raises.mojo`), and reassigning a `let` (`must_fail_let_assign.mojo`).

Where to go next

Chapter 2 is not optional. This compiler rejects a good deal of Mojo that current tutorials still teach, and knowing what changed will save you more time than anything else in this guide.

2. The language, as it is now

This chapter exists because most Mojo you will find written down does not compile here, for two separate reasons. Mojo itself moved and the writing did not; and this fork has since started changing the language deliberately, under the name cocoa-mojo.

Read this before you write anything substantial. Everything below was taken from the compiler's own source and standard library at the frozen commit.

This is cocoa-mojo, not upstream Mojo

The fork has stopped tracking upstream's declaration model and named itself. Where upstream removed something this port needs, it heals the language instead of working around the removal. Two keywords have come back with new, narrower meanings, and they are the first thing to learn.

The stance is recorded in the fork's own [COCOA_LET_DESIGN.md](#): new code here is deliberately a different dialect, and migration diagnostics teach rather than promise compatibility.

fn is back — as the foreign-callable function

Upstream removed `fn`. This fork revived it, but not as the old strict function. Here `fn` declares a **foreign-callable** function:

- **thin** — no captured context
- **non-raising** — the C boundary has no error channel
- **C ABI** — set automatically by the keyword
- every parameter and return type must be ABI-classifiable

That is exactly the contract an Objective-C `IMP` requires, which is the point.

```
fn add_one(x: Int) -> Int:
    return x + 1

fn button_clicked(self_: P, cmd: P, sender: P):
    clicks()[ ] += 1
```

You do not write `abi("C")` any more. The keyword says it.

An `fn` is still an ordinary callable from Mojo — `add_one(1)` works — so the keyword costs you nothing at the call site.

fn in type position

`fn(...) -> R` is sugar for the old `def(...) thin abi("C") -> R`:

```
comptime IntFn = fn(Int) -> Int

def apply(f: IntFn, x: Int) -> Int:
    return f(x)
```

The standard library's IMP aliases are now spelled this way, and read as what they are:

```
comptime IMP0 = fn(P, P, /) -> None
comptime IMP1 = fn(P, P, P, /) -> None
comptime IMP0Bool = fn(P, P, /) -> Bool
comptime IMP1Bool = fn(P, P, P, /) -> Bool
comptime IMP2 = fn(P, P, P, P, /) -> None
```

What fn rejects

Marking one `raises` is a compile error, and the message teaches rather than just refusing:

```
'fn' declares a foreign-callable (C ABI, non-raising) function in cocoa-mojo
and may not be marked 'raises'; use 'def' for an ordinary Mojo function
```

It comes with a FixIt that replaces `fn` with `def`. `async` is rejected the same way. Old code of the `fn main() raises` shape therefore gets told what changed instead of a bare contract violation.

let is back — as the immutable binding

`let` declares an **immutable, scope-bound binding**.

```
let win = ObjCObject(window_addr())[]
let n = 41 + 1
```

Three things to know.

The binding is immutable; the object is not. This is Swift's rule exactly. You cannot rebind `win`, but you can send it setters all day.

It is general. The design originally proposed gating `let` on a `Retained` trait so that only reference-counted Cocoa objects could use it. When it came to implementation the opposite was chosen: `let n = 42` and `let win = NSWindow(...)` both mean "immutable binding", which is one rule instead of two.

Ownership rides the value, not the keyword. For a Cocoa object held in an `ObjCRef`, `let` gives you the same +1-at-bind and release-at-scope-exit you already had with `var`; the ARC behaviour lives in `ObjCRef`. `let` adds only the immutability of the binding.

What let rejects

Reassignment is a compile error. And `let` is a **function-body** form only — there is no field or file-scope `let`:

```
'let' declares an immutable binding inside a function body; use 'var' for a
field or module value
```

When to reach for it

The fork's own conversion is a good guide: sixteen never-reassigned Cocoa bindings in `p0_window.mojo` became `let`. If you never rebind it, say so.

alias is deprecated, not removed

`alias` still parses, with a warning:

```
'alias' is deprecated; use 'comptime'
```

Use `comptime`. `alias` is gone from the standard library's own code.

comptime does the compile-time work

Argument conventions

There is no `inout`, no `borrowed`, and no `owned`. The conventions are:

Convention	Meaning
<i>(none)</i>	Borrowed immutably. The default; you do not write it.
<code>mut</code>	Borrowed mutably.
<code>out</code>	An uninitialised result the function must initialise. Used for <code>__init__</code> .
<code>var</code>	Taken by value; the callee owns it.
<code>deinit</code>	Consumes the value and ends its lifetime. Used for <code>__deinit__</code> and for consuming methods.

In practice:

```
def __init__(out self, *, adopt: ObjCObject):
    self._obj = adopt

def _add(mut self, selector: StaticString, encoding: String, imp: P):
    ...

def register(deinit self) -> ObjCClass:
    ...

def __iter__(var self) -> Self.IteratorOwnedType:
    ...
```

The transfer sigil `^` moves a value into a consuming position:

```
var cls = b^.register()      # b is consumed here
var delegate = new_instance(cls)
```

Forgetting `^` on a `deinit` method is one of the more common early errors.

Origins, and how they are spelled

References carry an origin parameter. The names were renamed twice and the old spellings have now been removed, so a tutorial written a few months ago will use identifiers that no longer exist.

Use this	Not this
<code>ImmOrigin</code>	<code>ImmutOrigin</code>
<code>ImmUnsafeAnyOrigin</code>	<code>ImmutUnsafeAnyOrigin</code>
<code>ImmStaticOrigin</code>	<code>StaticConstantOrigin</code>
<code>UntrackedOrigin</code>	<code>ExternalOrigin</code>
<code>MutUntrackedOrigin</code>	<code>MutExternalOrigin</code>
<code>ImmUntrackedOrigin</code>	<code>ImmutUntrackedOrigin</code> , <code>ImmutExternalOrigin</code>

`MutUntrackedOrigin` is the one you will type constantly in Cocoa code, because every pointer that crosses into Objective-C is outside Mojo's lifetime tracking by definition. Most CocoaMojo files start by shortening it:

```
comptime P = OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin]
```

Pointers

`Pointer` is the type. `UnsafePointer` still exists but is deprecated in favour of it, and the pre-unification aliases — `MutUnsafePointer`, `ImmUnsafePointer`, `ImmutOpaquePointer`, `OptionalUnsafePointer` and the rest — have been removed outright.

```
var p = Pointer[UInt8, MutUntrackedOrigin](unsafe_from_address=addr)
var q = OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin](unsafe_from_address=addr)
```

The raw memory functions were renamed to carry an `unsafe_` prefix, and the old names are gone: use `unsafe_memcpy`, `unsafe_memset`, `unsafe_memset_zero`, `unsafe_destroy_n`. Likewise the `Pointer` methods are now `unsafe_deinit_pointee()`, `unsafe_write()`, `unsafe_as_noalias()`.

Function types, thin, and abi("C")

`fn` is the spelling you want for a foreign-callable function, but the longhand still exists and you will meet it in older code and in diagnostics.

```
comptime IMP1 = fn(P, P, P, /) -> None          # cocoa-mojo
comptime IMP1 = def(P, P, P, /) thin abi("C") -> None  # the longhand it sugars
```

/ ends the positional-only parameters, `thin` means the function carries no captured context, and `abi("C")` gives it the C calling convention. You need all three for a Cocoa callback, because the Objective-C runtime calls a bare C function pointer with no closure environment — which is precisely why `fn` bundles them into one keyword.

A `thin` function type can also carry trailing `where` clauses constraining the parameters it declares, so a generic algorithm can state what it requires of a function handed to it rather than restating the constraint at every binding site.

One consequence worth knowing: **a `thin fn` is exactly a global block**. An Objective-C block with no captures is `_NSConcreteGlobalBlock` with no copy/dispose helpers, so the standard library can build a block around any `fn` at no cost. That is how block-only Cocoa APIs are reachable today — see [Concurrency and blocks](#).

Parameters and generics

Parameters go in square brackets and are resolved at compile time. Arguments go in parentheses.

```
def msg_send[
  R: AnyType,
  cls: StaticString,
  selector: StaticString,
  is_class: Bool = False,
  *Ts: AnyType,
](obj: ObjCObject, *args: *Ts) -> R:
  ...
```

That signature shows most of what you need: a type parameter, string parameters, a defaulted `Bool` parameter, a variadic type-parameter pack, and a value pack `*args: *Ts` bound to it.

Overloading works on parameter lists as well as argument lists, which is how `ObjCClassBuilder.add_method` accepts five different IMP shapes under one name.

Structs and traits

```
@fieldwise_init
struct CGPoint(Copyable, Movable):
  var x: Float64
  var y: Float64
```

`@fieldwise_init` synthesises the memberwise initialiser. Conformances go in the parentheses. The ones you will meet most in Cocoa code are `Copyable`, `Movable`, `AnyType` and `TrivialRegisterPassable`.

Two more renames that will bite: `ImplicitlyDestructible` and `ImplicitlyDeletable` are now `Deinitable`, and `@explicit_destroy` is no longer required, because implicit deletion is the default.

Destructors are `__deinit__`, taking `deinit self`:

```
def __deinit__(deinit self):
```

```
if not self._obj.is_nil():
    ...
```

Other removals you are likely to trip over

Gone	Use instead
<code>InlineArray</code>	<code>Array</code>
<code>SIMD.size</code> , <code>Array.size</code> , <code>SIMDSIZE</code>	<code>length</code> , <code>SIMDLength</code>
<code>String.as_string_slice()</code>	<code>StringSpan(my_string)</code>
<code>as_immutable()</code> , <code>get_immutable()</code>	<code>as_imm()</code>
<code>ImmutSpan</code>	<code>ImmSpan</code>
<code>ConditionalType</code>	the ternary <code>T if cond else U</code>
<code>trait_downcast()</code>	a where clause or <code>comptime assert with conforms_to(...)</code>
<code>.mojopkg</code> files	<code>.mojoc</code> files
<code>memcmp</code>	<code>unsafe_memcmp</code>
<code>List.steal_data()</code>	<code>unsafe_take_allocation()</code>
<code>OwnedPointer.take()</code>	<code>into_inner()</code>
<code>Variant.take()</code>	<code>unwrap()</code>
<code>std.gpu.profiler / ProfileBlock</code>	<code>perf_counter_ns()</code> , or a real GPU profiler

The module system also tightened. Importing same-named functions from different modules to build one overload set is now an error, and intra-package access without an explicit `import` is an error. Both had deprecation periods that have now expired.

async on an fn

`fn` cannot be `async`; use `def`. The rest of the `async` story is unchanged from upstream, and nothing in `CocoaMojo` depends on it.

A note on async

`AnyCoroutine`, `Coroutine` and `RaisingCoroutine` are no longer in the prelude and the module defining them is private. `async def` still works and the compiler still synthesises those types — you simply cannot name them. `Mojo`'s `async` support is unfinished and nothing in `CocoaMojo` depends on it.

What you can rely on

The point of the freeze is that this list will not move under you. Code written against this chapter keeps compiling for as long as you keep the compiler. That is the trade the fork makes: no upstream fixes and

no new features, in exchange for a language that stays still long enough to build something on.

3. Calling Cocoa

Every Objective-C method call is one C function call:

```
objc_msgSend(id self, SEL op, ...)
```

Binding that is not hard because of the call. It is hard because of everything the call depends on — does this class have this selector, what does it return, which register file does each argument travel in — and all of that lives in the SDK, where it is traditionally transcribed by hand, once, wrongly.

`msg_send` gets those facts from the database while your program compiles.

First: load the framework

Foundation arrives free — something in every process drags it in. **AppKit does not**, unless the binary was linked against it. In a JIT-run program (`mojo run`) nothing was, so

`objc_getClass("NSApplication")` returns nil and every message to it silently no-ops. The app "runs", exits without a window, and produces no diagnostic anywhere.

That failure shape cost the fork real time. Call this first in anything windowed:

```
if not load_framework["AppKit"]():  
    raise Error("could not load AppKit")
```

It is a `dlopen` with `RTLD_NOW`, idempotent and cheap after the first call.

Looking up a class

```
var cls = ObjCClass.lookup["NSString"]()  
if cls.is_nil():  
    print("NSString not registered – is Foundation linked?")
```

The name is a *parameter*, in square brackets, because it is resolved at compile time. `is_nil()` is worth checking once at startup: a nil class means the framework was never loaded, and every subsequent message will silently do nothing.

`ObjCClass` and `ObjCObject` are distinct types even though both are pointers at the C ABI, so you cannot pass one where the other is expected. Convert deliberately:

```
var as_obj = cls.as_object()
```

Sending a message

```
var n = msg_send[Int, "NSString", "length"](s)
```

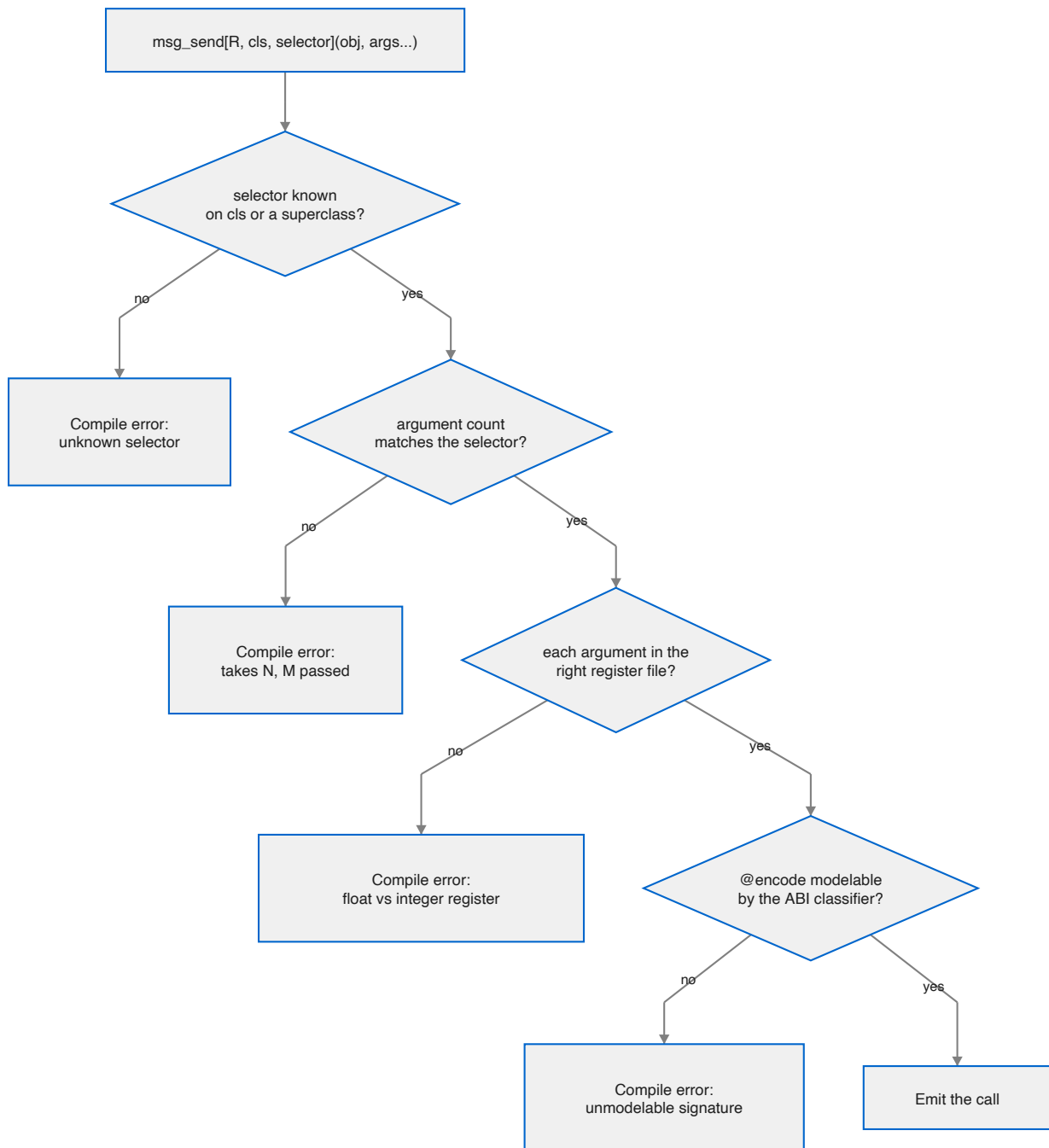
Read the parameters left to right: the **return type**, the **class the selector is looked up on**, and the **selector**. Then the receiver in parentheses.

For a class method, add `is_class=True`:

```
var s = msg_send[
    NSObject, "NSString", "stringWithUTF8String:", is_class=True
](cls.as_object(), text.as_c_string_slice())
```

Arguments follow the receiver. The colons in the selector tell you how many to expect — `stringWithUTF8String:` takes one, `length` takes none — and the compiler checks that you passed the right number.

What gets checked, and when



Four checks, all before code generation. Taking them in turn:

The selector must exist. The lookup walks the superclass chain in the metadata, so asking `NSMutableString` about `length` correctly finds `NSString`'s definition. A misspelling has nowhere to hide.

The argument count must match. This is the check that saves you from the worst class of bug. Call `characterAtIndex:` with no index and the callee reads whatever happened to be in the argument register — a plausible-looking number, a crash much later, or nothing at all. Here it is a compile error, and the fork ships it as a must-fail test.

Each argument must be in the right register file. On AAPCS64 a scalar float travels in `v0–v7` and everything else in the general-purpose registers. Passing an `Int` where the ABI wants a `Float64` is not a conversion; it is reading the wrong register. `msg_send` flags the cases it is certain about — a scalar float against an integer class, and the reverse — and stays quiet about structs and unknowns so there are no false positives.

The signature must be modelable. If the ABI classifier cannot make sense of a method's `@encode` string it answers `"?"`, and that is a compile error rather than a guess. This is the check that matters least often and matters most when it fires.

Return types

The return type parameter is what the C ABI sees, so pick the Mojo type that matches the Objective-C one:

Objective-C	Mojo return parameter
id, any object	ObjCObject
NSUInteger, NSInteger	Int
BOOL	Bool
unichar	UInt16
double, CGFloat	Float64
const char *	OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin]
void	assign to <code>_</code> and ignore

A `void` method still returns something as far as Mojo is concerned, so the idiom is:

```
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "setDelegate:"](app, delegate.ptr())
```

You will write `_ =` constantly. It is not a wart; it is the compiler refusing to let you silently discard a value.

Struct returns, and why arm64 makes them boring

On x86-64, a method returning a large struct must go through a completely different entry point, `objc_msgSend_stret`, with a hidden buffer pointer in `rdi` and the receiver shifted to `rsi`. Getting that wrong corrupts the stack.

On arm64 there is no `objc_msgSend_stret` and no `objc_msgSend_fpret`. They do not exist in this machine's `libobjc`, because AAPCS64 does not need them: a small aggregate comes back in `x0–x1`, a homogeneous float aggregate in `v0–v3`, and anything larger through the `x8` indirect-result register. All of that happens through the ordinary `send`.

So `cocoakb_msgsend_variant` always answers `"objc_msgSend"` here. The query is kept anyway, because its *other* job survives: an unmodelable signature still answers `"?"` and still fails the build.

A concrete case worth internalising: `-[NSValue rectValue]` returns a `CGRect`, which is 32 bytes. On x86-64 that is a `_stret` call. Here it classifies as `h4` — a homogeneous float aggregate of four doubles — and comes back in `v0-v3` from a plain `objc_msgSend`.

Protocol-typed receivers: send

`msg_send` needs a class name to look the selector up on. Sometimes you do not have one. Every Metal object is declared as a protocol — `id<MTLDevice>`, `id<MTLTexture>` — and so is every Cocoa delegate. The concrete class is a private implementation detail you cannot name.

For those, use `send`, which is keyed by selector alone:

```
var tex = send[ObjCObject, "newTextureWithDescriptor:"](device, desc.ptr())
```

The dispatch stub and the argument classes come from any class in the database that implements the selector, which is consistent across implementors. You keep the argument-count check and the register-file check. The only thing you give up is verification that this particular receiver responds to it.

The trade is explicit, and the error when a selector is implemented by nothing at all is clear:

```
std.objc: no class in the metadata implements selector 'newTextureWithDesc:',  
so its dispatch ABI is unknown. Check the selector spelling.
```

Selectors

`sel[...]` registers a selector and caches it:

```
var s = sel["applicationDidFinishLaunching:"]()
```

The resolved `SEL` is cached in a per-selector global slot, deduplicated by name in the KGEN lowering, so every call site for a given selector shares one slot. After the first send, resolving a selector is a load and a branch-predicted-away null check — not a hash lookup and not a runtime registry call.

You rarely call `sel` directly; `msg_send` does it for you. You need it when talking to `class_addMethod` or `respondToSelector:`.

Strings

`NSString` is the type you will convert most, and there are three levels of convenience.

The raw send, when you want to see the machinery:

```
var s = msg_send[  
    ObjCObject, "NSString", "stringWithUTF8String:", is_class=True  
](cls.as_object(), text.as_c_string_slice())
```

`nsstring`, for handing an autoreleased string to an AppKit setter that will retain it:

```
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "setTitle:"](win, nsstring("Life").ptr())
```

And `NSString`, a leak-safe owning wrapper, when the string outlives the statement:

```
var greeting = NSString("Hello")
print(greeting.length())
print(greeting.to_string())
```

Going the other way, `ns_to_string` is the direction that used to be missing:

```
var text = ns_to_string(some_nsstring)
```

It copies out as UTF-8, so the result does not depend on the pool that owns the `NSString`. Underneath it is still `-UTF8String`, which you can call yourself when you want the raw pointer:

```
var p = msg_send[
    OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin], "NSString", "UTF8String"
](s)
var text = String(unsafe_from_utf8_ptr=p.bitcast[c_char]())
```

Errors: NSError becomes raises

Cocoa's error convention predates the exceptions it never adopted. A fallible method takes a trailing `error:` out-parameter (`NSError **`) and signals failure **through its return value** — `nil` for object returns, `NO` for `BOOL` returns. The error object is only meaningful when the return value says failure.

Checking the out-parameter instead of the return value is the classic Cocoa bug. Ignoring it throws the diagnosis away — which is exactly what this codebase used to do, with an `err_out()` sink that discarded every message.

Two wrappers convert the convention to Mojo's:

```
# Object convention: nil means failure.
var contents = msg_send_raising[
    "NSString", "stringWithContentsOfFile:encoding:error:", is_class=True
](ns_string_cls, path.ptr(), Int(4))

# BOOL convention: NO means failure. Returns nothing.
msg_send_raising_check[
    "NSString", "writeToFile:atomically:encoding:error:"
](nsstring("round trip"), path.ptr(), Bool(True), Int(4))
```

Do not pass the error argument. The wrapper creates the stack slot and appends it for you. Pass the message arguments without it.

On failure you get a Mojo `Error` whose message carries Cocoa's own diagnosis — the `localizedDescription`, plus domain and code:

```
stringWithContentsOfFile:encoding:error:: The file "really-not-here.txt"
couldn't be opened because there is no such file. (NSCocoaErrorDomain 260)
```

Everything `msg_send` checks is still checked. The selector must exist, the register-file classes are verified, and the argument count includes the error slot the wrapper supplies — all at compile time.

Two limits worth knowing. The wrappers are declared at explicit arities up to five leading arguments, because Mojo permits nothing after an unpacked `*args` so the slot cannot be appended to a forwarded pack. That covers the SDK's convention comfortably, and a new arity is four lines. And if an API returns failure without writing an error, you get a message saying so rather than a crash.

Enum constants

Cocoa's named constants come from `BridgeSupport`, resolved at compile time:

```
comptime titled = cocoakb_enum_value["NSWindowStyleMaskTitled"]()
comptime utf8 = cocoakb_enum_value["NSUTF8StringEncoding"]() # 4
```

Use these instead of typing the numbers. The one place you will be tempted to cheat is style masks, where `15` is quicker to write than four lookups — the example applications do exactly that, and it is the kind of shortcut that survives right up until Apple rennumbers something.

Extern object constants

Constants like `NSForegroundColorAttributeName` are not values the metadata can hand over at compile time. They are globals whose address the linker resolves. `extern_object` takes a link-time reference to the data symbol and loads the pointer out of it:

```
var key = extern_object["NSForegroundColorAttributeName"]()
```

Struct layouts

Declare the struct in Mojo, then assert that your declaration agrees with the SDK:

```
@fieldwise_init
struct CGPoint(Copyable, Movable):
    var x: Float64
    var y: Float64

@fieldwise_init
struct CGSize(Copyable, Movable):
    var width: Float64
    var height: Float64

@fieldwise_init
struct CGRect(Copyable, Movable):
    var origin: CGPoint
    var size: CGSize

comptime assert size_of[CGRect]() == cocoakb_struct_size["CGRect"]()
comptime assert align_of[CGRect]() == cocoakb_struct_align["CGRect"]()
```

```
comptime assert cocoakb_field_offset["CGRect", "size"]() == 16
```

This is the part people skip, and it is the part that pays. A wrong field offset does not fail loudly — it reads a filename out of the middle of a timestamp. Most sample code you will find online quotes 32-bit offsets; `WIN32_FIND_DATAW`'s equivalent trap exists on every platform. Assert, and the build tells you.

Once the assertions pass you can pass the struct by value straight through a send, and the C ABI does the register allocation:

```
win = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "initWithContentRect:styleMask:backing:defer:"
](
    win,
    CGRect(CGPoint(100.0, 100.0), CGSize(1080.0, 720.0)),
    Int(15),
    Int(2),
    Bool(False),
)
```

4. Ownership and memory

Cocoa manages memory by reference counting. An object is created at +1, every `retain` adds one, every `release` takes one away, and at zero it is deallocated. Autorelease pools defer a release to the end of a scope.

Mojo has value semantics and deterministic destruction. CocoaMojo binds the two so that the Objective-C reference count follows the lifetime of the Mojo value holding it — which means **you opt out of correct memory management, never into it.**

ObjCRef owns a +1

```
struct ObjCRef(Movable):  
    ...
```

An `ObjCRef` holds one owned reference. It releases when the Mojo value is destroyed. There are two ways to make one, and picking the right one is the whole skill.

```
var owned = ObjCRef(adopt=obj)    # you already own a +1  
var shared = ObjCRef(retain=obj)  # you only borrowed it; add a +1
```

The rule that decides which is the oldest rule in Cocoa, and it is mechanical:

Selector you called	You own the result?	Use
<code>alloc</code> , <code>new</code> , <code>copy</code> , <code>mutableCopy</code>	yes, +1	<code>adopt=</code>
anything else	no, borrowed	<code>retain=</code>

Get this backwards in the `adopt` direction and you over-release, which crashes somewhere unrelated. Get it backwards in the `retain` direction and you leak.

The classic +1 chain

```
def make_array() -> ObjCRef:  
    var cls = ObjCClass.lookup["NSMutableArray"]()  
    var allocated = msg_send[  
        ObjCObject, "NSMutableArray", "alloc", is_class=True  
    ](cls.as_object())  
    var initd = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSObject", "init"](allocated)  
    return ObjCRef(adopt=initd)
```

`alloc` returns +1, `init` consumes and returns it, and `adopt=` takes over. The caller cannot forget to release, because there is nothing to forget: the `ObjCRef` releases when it dies.

The fork's ownership test cycles a million of these and watches memory stay flat.

Copying is an explicit retain

`ObjCRef` is `Movable` but not implicitly `Copyable`. Sharing an Objective-C object means retaining it, and the design makes that visible:

```
var a = make_array()
var b = a.copy()      # a visible +1
```

If you want to move rather than share, use the transfer sigil:

```
var b = a^
```

Autorelease pools

```
with autoreleasepool():
    var s = make_autoreleased()
    print("live inside the pool:", not s.is_nil())
# pool drained here
```

`autoreleasepool` pushes a pool on entry and pops it on exit. It guards against a double pop internally, because popping a token twice corrupts the pool page and produces a hard crash a long way from the cause.

Wrap `main` in one. Wrap any loop that creates many temporary Cocoa objects in one. Do **not** wrap an AppKit callback in one — AppKit's own event dispatch already has a pool active, and every object you read from an event is autoreleased by the caller.

Returning an object without leaking

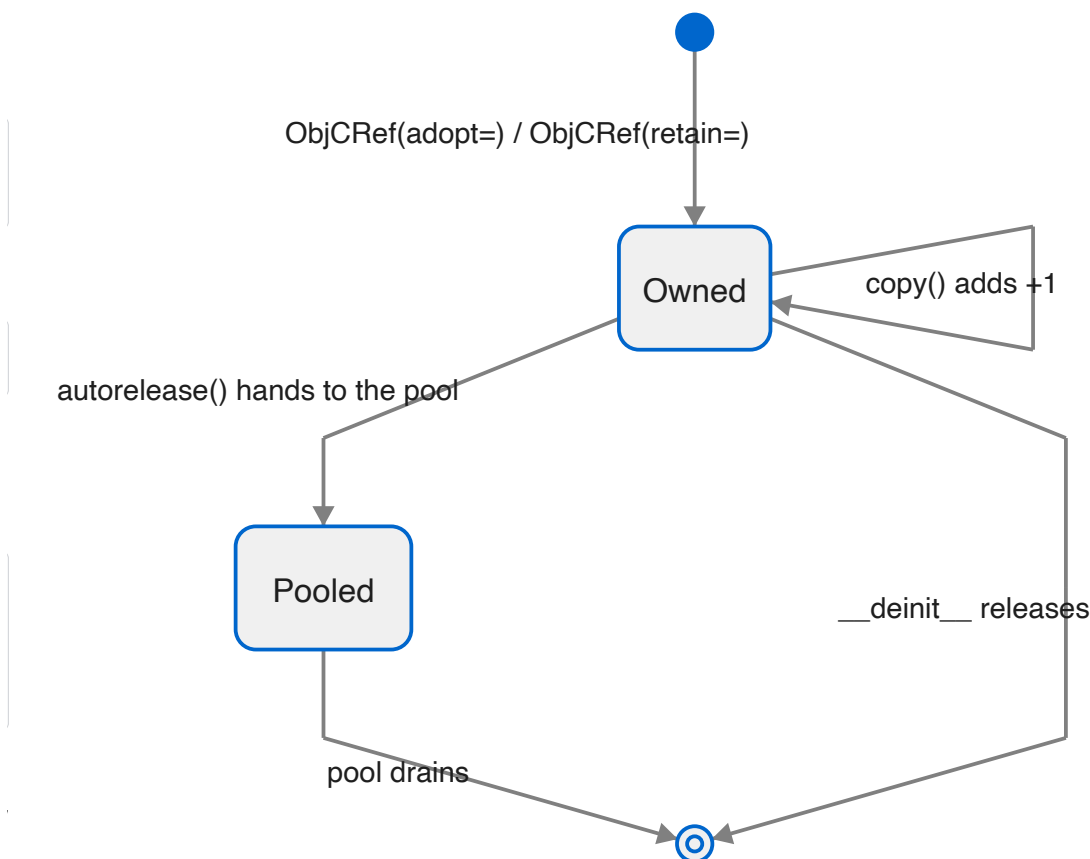
Sometimes you want to hand an object back without making the caller own it — exactly what an Objective-C method returning an autoreleased object does. `autorelease()` consumes the `ObjCRef` and gives the object to the current pool:

```
def make_autoreleased() -> ObjCObject:
    var owned = make_array()
    return owned^.autorelease()
```

Note the `^`. `autorelease` takes `deinit self`, so the reference is consumed; without the sigil you get a compile error.

The returned `ObjCObject` is valid until the pool drains. Using it afterwards is a use-after-free, and no amount of compile-time checking can save you from that one — it is the one place in CocoaMojo where the discipline is yours.

The lifetime, as a state machine



let for the bindings you never rebind

Everything above works the same whether you bind with `var` or `let`. The ARC behaviour lives in `ObjCRef`, not in the keyword.

```
let obj = make_array()           # +1 at bind, released at scope exit
let s = nsstring("hello")
```

What `let` adds is that the *binding* cannot be reassigned, which is worth having precisely because Cocoa code is full of handles you obtain once and then only send messages to. If you never rebind it, say so; the compiler will hold you to it.

The object stays mutable. `let win = ...` then `setTitle:` is fine — you are mutating the object, not rebinding the name.

Weak references

`ObjCRef` is the strong half of the story. `ObjCWeakRef` is the other half, and you need it more often than you might expect, because **Cocoa's delegate convention is weak**. A window does not own its delegate; an observer does not own its target. Holding an `ObjCRef` where Cocoa expects weakness is a retain cycle that leaks both sides.

```
var strong = make_object()
var weak = ObjCWeakRef(strong.object())

var loaded = weak.load()      # an ObjCRef: the object at +1, or nil
if loaded.is_nil():
    print("gone")
```

It is a **zeroing** weak reference: while the object lives, `load()` returns it; after the last strong reference goes, `load()` returns nil. A weak reference to nil is legal and simply loads nil.

Three details that matter in use.

load() returns an owned ObjCRef, not a bare handle. It goes through `objc_loadWeakRetained`, so the object cannot be deallocated between your nil-check and your use. That is the entire reason to load a weak reference rather than peek at it.

Copying is explicit, matching `ObjCRef`:

```
var weak2 = weak.copy()      # an independent registration
```

There is one small heap allocation per weak reference, and the reason is worth understanding. The Objective-C runtime tracks a weak reference *by the address of the slot holding it*. Mojo values move. If the slot were a struct field, any move would leave the runtime pointing into a dead stack frame — a corruption with no diagnostic. So the slot lives on the heap, its address stays stable for the life of the value, and moving the struct moves only a pointer. Delegates are few; the allocation is not a problem.

A rough edge

Assigning into an uninitialised `var` of a type with a `__deinit__` destroys garbage first and crashes. This is pre-existing and not specific to weak references, but it bites here because the natural shape —

```
var weak: ObjCWeakRef      # then assign later
```

— is exactly that pattern. Bind it in a helper scope and return it instead.

Buffers that Cocoa callbacks must reach

This one is not about Objective-C at all, and it will catch you.

Mojo destroys a value at its **last use**, not at the end of scope. So a `List` whose `.unsafe_ptr()` you stash in a global is freed immediately after that line, and every stored pointer dangles. The symptom arrives much later as a corrupted allocator, nowhere near the cause.

When memory has to outlive Mojo's view of it, own it outside Mojo:

```
def alloc_zeroed(count: Int, size: Int) -> Int:
    var sym = _sym["calloc"]()
    var call = Pointer(to=sym).unsafe_bitcast[
        def(Int, Int, /) thin abi("C") -> P
    ]()[]
    return Int(call(count, size))
```

Explicit, unowned, and correct. The alternative — hoping a `List` lives long enough — is not a smaller amount of unsafety, only a less visible one.

Where callback state lives

Cocoa callbacks are bare C function pointers. They get no closure and no context argument you did not arrange yourself. State they need must therefore live somewhere reachable by name.

```
comptime g_running = named_global["life.running", Int]
comptime g_gen = named_global["life.gen", Int]

# read and write through the pointer
g_running()[0] = 1
var generation = g_gen()[0]
```

`named_global` gives you one zero-initialised process global per name, shared across every call site, because KGEN deduplicates the global by name. It is the plainest possible answer to a real constraint, and it is better than the alternative of smuggling a pointer through `setRepresentedObject:` and casting it back.

A short checklist

Use `adopt=` after `alloc`, `new`, `copy`, `mutableCopy`; `retain=` otherwise. Use `^` when consuming an `ObjCRef`. Wrap `main` and long loops in `autoreleasepool`, but not AppKit callbacks. Allocate anything a callback must reach outside Mojo's ownership, and reach it through `named_global`.

5. Letting Cocoa call you

Everything interactive in Cocoa works the same way: you supply an object, and the framework sends it a selector. Target/action, delegates, notification observers, timers — all of it.

To supply such an object from Mojo you define an Objective-C class at run time, add methods whose implementations are Mojo `fn` functions, and register it. `ObjCClassBuilder` wraps the three runtime calls that do this.

The shape of a callback

An Objective-C method implementation, an `IMP`, is a C function whose first two arguments are always the receiver and the selector:

```
void method(id self, SEL _cmd, ...);
```

In cocoa-mojo you declare that with `fn`:

```
fn button_clicked(self_: P, cmd: P, sender: P):
    clicks()[] += 1
    set_label(String("Clicked ") + String(clicks()[]) + " times")

fn should_terminate_after_last_window(self_: P, cmd: P, app: P) -> Bool:
    return True
```

`fn` is the contract `class_addMethod` requires — thin, non-raising, C ABI — so the keyword now says what the function is instead of the old costume:

```
def button_clicked(self_: P, cmd: P, sender: P) abi("C"): # the old spelling
fn button_clicked(self_: P, cmd: P, sender: P):           # cocoa-mojo
```

`self_` has a trailing underscore because `self` is reserved. `cmd` you will almost never use, but you must still declare it: the design proposes a trampoline that injects the `_cmd` slot for you, and that is **not implemented yet**. Write all three parameters.

Five IMP shapes are predeclared, and `add_method` overloads across them:

Alias	Signature
IMP0	<code>fn(P, P, /) -> None</code>
IMP1	<code>fn(P, P, P, /) -> None</code>
IMP0Bool	<code>fn(P, P, /) -> Bool</code>
IMP1Bool	<code>fn(P, P, P, /) -> Bool</code>
IMP2	<code>fn(P, P, P, P, /) -> None</code>

If your callback does not fit one of these you are past what `ObjCClassBuilder` covers and into `class_addMethod` by hand — the pattern is in the fork's `callback_probe.mojo` spike.

What fn will not let you write

A callback that can raise is a compile error at the definition, not a crash inside Cocoa's event loop later:

```
'fn' declares a foreign-callable (C ABI, non-raising) function in cocoa-mojo
and may not be marked 'raises'; use 'def' for an ordinary Mojo function
```

That is the point of the keyword. The C boundary has no error channel, so a raising callback was always a latent crash; now it does not compile.

Building a class

```
var b = ObjCClassBuilder("MyDelegate")          # subclass of NSObject
b.add_method["applicationDidFinishLaunching:"](did_launch)
var cls = b^.register()
var delegate = new_instance(cls)
```

To subclass something other than `NSObject`, name it as a parameter:

```
var vb = ObjCClassBuilder["NSView"]("LifeView")
vb.add_method["mouseDown:"](on_mouse_down)
vb.add_method["keyDown:"](on_key_down)
vb.add_method["acceptsFirstResponder"](accepts_first_responder)
var LifeView = vb^.register()
```

`register()` takes `deinit self`, so it consumes the builder — hence `b^`. A class can be registered exactly once, and the type system enforces it.

Where the type encoding comes from

`class_addMethod` needs a *method type encoding*: a string like `"v@:@"` telling the runtime the ABI of the implementation. Getting it wrong produces argument corruption, not a diagnostic.

For any selector the SDK knows, you do not write it. The builder looks it up:

```
b.add_method["applicationDidFinishLaunching:"](did_launch)
```

The database returns `"v24@0:8@16"` — the runtime's `@encode` carries frame offsets — and the builder strips the digits to leave `"v@:@"`, which is what `class_addMethod` wants.

For a selector the SDK has never heard of, because you invented it, pass the encoding yourself:

```
ab.add_method["tick:", encoding="v@:@"](on_tick)
```

Omitting `encoding=` on an unknown selector is a compile error telling you to supply it. That is the correct behaviour: the alternative is a guess.

Reading `"v@:@": return void`, then `self (@)`, then `_cmd (:)`, then one object argument (`@`). The common encodings are in the [reference](#).

A worked example: a timer target

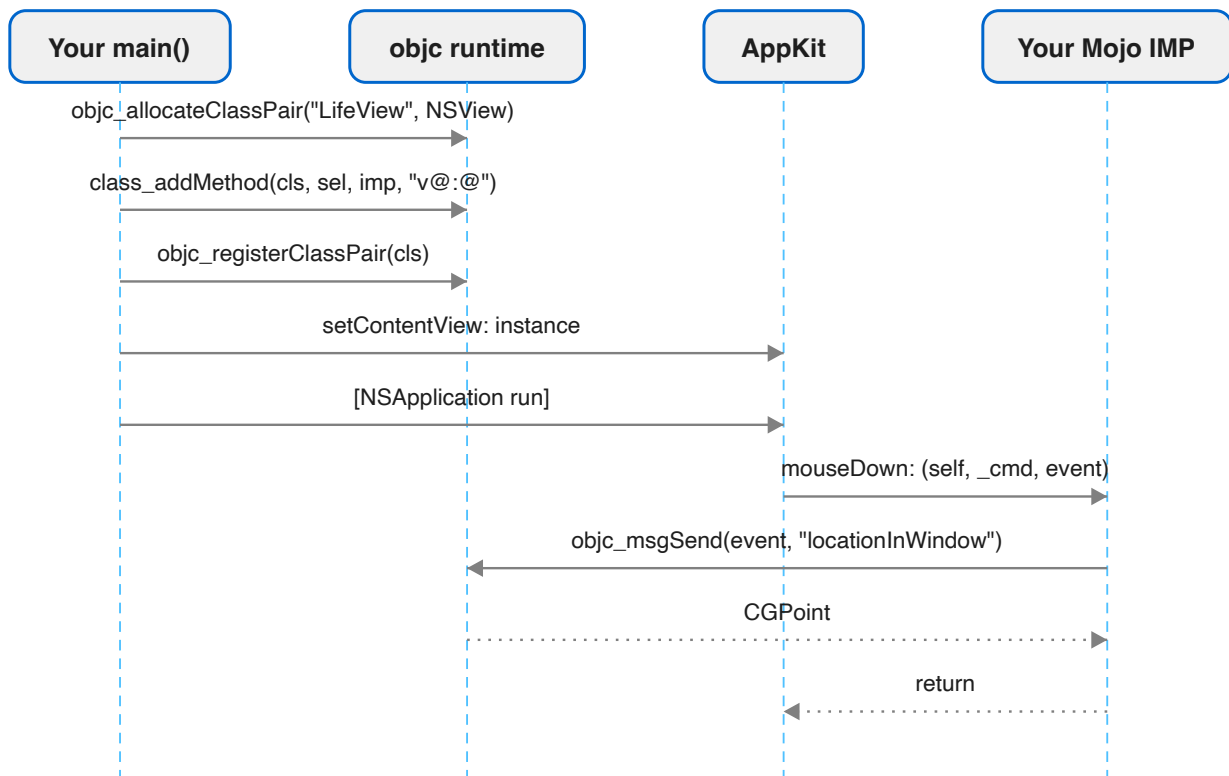
```
fn on_tick(self_: P, cmd: P, timer: P):
    step_simulation()
    redraw()

# ...

var ab = ObjCClassBuilder("LifeActions")
ab.add_method["tick:", encoding="v@:@"](on_tick)
var actions = new_instance(ab^.register())
_ = external_call["objc_retain", P](actions.ptr())
```

That last line matters. `new_instance` gives you a +1, but the value is about to go out of scope while Cocoa still holds a bare pointer to it. Retaining it deliberately, and never releasing, is correct for an object that must live as long as the application. It is a leak in the strict sense and the right answer in practice.

The round trip



The encoding passed to `class_addMethod` in the second step is the one the SDK database supplied; nothing in that sequence was typed by hand except the selector names.

Verifying it worked

`respondsToSelector:` is the cheap check, and worth doing once during bring-up:

```
var responds = msg_send[Bool, "NSObject", "respondsToSelector:"](inst, s)
print("responds:", responds)
```

If that prints `False`, the usual causes are a selector spelled differently from the one you added, or a `register()` that never ran.

Delegates

A delegate is only an object implementing the right selectors. There is no protocol conformance to declare at run time:

```
var db = ObjCClassBuilder("LifeDelegate")
db.add_method["applicationShouldTerminateAfterLastWindowClosed:"]({
    should_terminate
})
var delegate = new_instance(db^.register())
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "setDelegate:"](app, delegate.ptr())
```

Because the selector is a real AppKit one, its encoding comes from the database and you never type `"c@:@"` — which, incidentally, is the encoding people most often get wrong, since `BOOL` is `c` and not `B`.

Reading arguments out of an event

Callback arguments arrive as raw pointers. Wrap and send:

```
def event_has_shift(event: P) -> Bool:
    var flags = msg_send[Int, "NSEvent", "modifierFlags"](
        ObjCObject(Int(event))
    )
    return (flags & 131072) != 0    # NSEventModifierFlagShift
```

That magic number should be `cocoa_kb_enum_value["NSEventModifierFlagShift"]()`. The example applications hardcode several of these, and it is the one habit in them worth not copying.

Reading a keystroke is the same pattern with a string on the end:

```
fn on_key_down(self_: P, cmd: P, event: P):
    var chars = msg_send[
        ObjCObject, "NSEvent", "charactersIgnoringModifiers"
    ](ObjCObject(Int(event)))
    if chars.is_nil():
        return
    var p = msg_send[P, "NSString", "UTF8String"](chars)
    if Int(p) == 0:
```

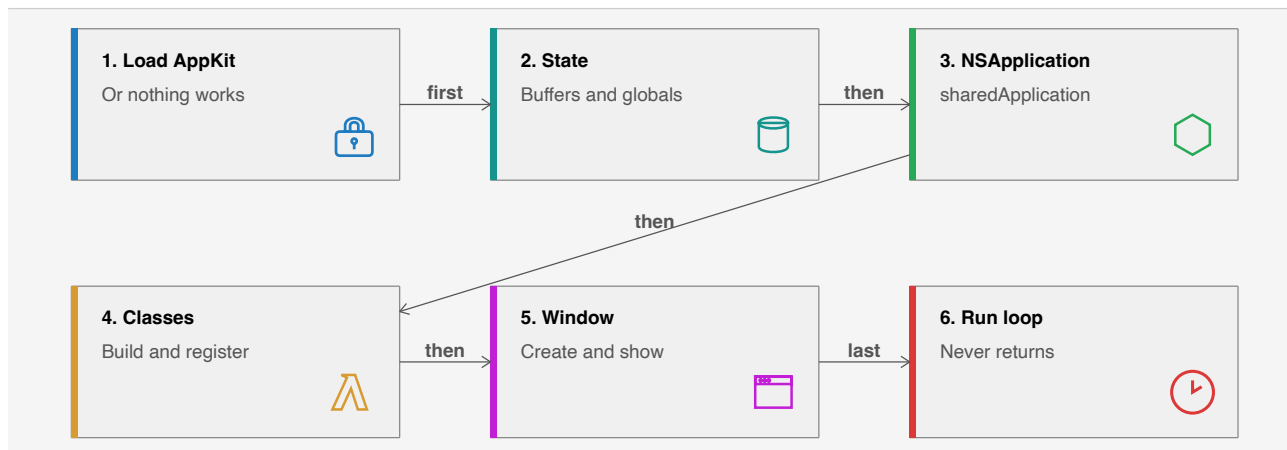
```
        return
    var s = String(unsafe_from_utf8_ptr=p.unsafe_bitcast[c_char]())
    if len(s.as_bytes()) == 0:
        return
    var c = s.as_bytes()[0]
    if c == UInt8(ord(" ")):
        toggle_running()
```

Three nil checks before touching anything. AppKit will hand you a nil string for a dead key, and a null `UTF8String` for an empty one.

6. A complete application

Everything so far assembles into one shape. This chapter is that shape, in the order it has to happen, with the reasons.

The skeleton



Order matters. A class must be registered before anything is instantiated from it, and the application object must exist before a window is made key. Getting either backwards produces a silent failure rather than an error.

Step 0 — load AppKit

```
def main() raises:
    if not load_framework["AppKit"]():
        raise Error("could not load AppKit")
```

Nothing linked AppKit into a `mojo run` process, so without this every AppKit class lookup returns nil and every message to it silently does nothing. The program starts and exits with no window and no diagnostic. Put it first.

Step 1 — state, before anything else

```
g_alive()[ ] = alloc_zeroed(CELLS, 1)
g_next()[ ] = alloc_zeroed(CELLS, 1)
g_frame()[ ] = alloc_zeroed(PIXELS, 4)
g_running()[ ] = 1
randomize()
```

Do this first because the callbacks you are about to install can fire the moment the run loop starts, and a callback that reads a null global crashes on the first frame.

Step 2 — the application object

```
with autoreleasepool():
    var NSApplication = ObjCClass.lookup["NSApplication"]()
    var app = msg_send[
        NSObject, "NSApplication", "sharedApplication", is_class=True
    ](NSApplication.as_object())
    _ = msg_send[Bool, "NSApplication", "setActivationPolicy:"](app, Int(0))
```

`setActivationPolicy:` with `0` is `NSApplicationActivationPolicyRegular` — the difference between a real application with a Dock icon and menu bar, and a process that puts a window on screen that cannot be focused. Skipping it is the most common reason a first CocoaMojo window appears dead.

Step 3 — classes

The delegate:

```
var db = ObjCClassBuilder("LifeDelegate")
db.add_method["applicationShouldTerminateAfterLastWindowClosed:"](  
    should_terminate  
)
var delegate = new_instance(db^.register())
_ = msg_send[NSObject, "NSApplication", "setDelegate:"](  
    app, delegate.ptr()  
)
```

The view, whose event handlers are Mojo functions:

```
var vb = ObjCClassBuilder["NSView"]("LifeView")
vb.add_method["mouseDown:"](  
    on_mouse_down  
)
vb.add_method["mouseDragged:"](  
    on_mouse_dragged  
)
vb.add_method["keyDown:"](  
    on_key_down  
)
vb.add_method["acceptsFirstResponder"](  
    accepts_first_responder  
)
var LifeView = vb^.register()
```

`acceptsFirstResponder` returning `True` is what makes the view eligible to receive key events at all. Without it `keyDown:` never fires and the view looks broken in a way that gives no clue.

Step 4 — window and view

```
var win = msg_send[NSObject, "NSWindow", "alloc", is_class=True](  
    ObjCClass.lookup["NSWindow"]().as_object()  
)
win = msg_send[  
    NSObject,  
    "NSWindow",  
    "initWithContentRect:styleMask:backing:defer:",  
](
```

```

        win,
        CGRect(CGPoint(100.0, 100.0), CGSize(1080.0, 720.0)),
        Int(15),
        Int(2),
        Bool(False),
    )
    g_window()[0] = win.addr()

```

The `15` is a style mask — titled, closable, miniaturisable, resizable — and should really be four `cocoa_kb_enum_value` lookups combined. The `2` is `NSBackingStoreBuffered`.

Then the view, and making the window visible:

```

var view = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSView", "alloc", is_class=True](
    LifeView.as_object()
)
view = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSView", "initWithFrame:"](view, frame)
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "setContentView:"](win, view.ptr())
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "makeKeyAndOrderFront:"](
    win, ObjCObject(0).ptr()
)
_ = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "activateIgnoringOtherApps:"
](app, Bool(True))

```

Step 5 — the run loop

```

var app2 = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "sharedApplication", is_class=True
](ObjCClass.lookup["NSApplication"]().as_object())
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "run"](app2)

```

`run` does not return until the application terminates. Note that it is deliberately **outside** the `autoreleasepool` block: the pool should drain the setup objects before the loop begins, and the loop maintains its own pools per event cycle.

Re-fetching `sharedApplication` rather than reusing `app` is not superstition — `app` was bound inside the `with` block that has now ended.

What you get

The fork ships three applications built exactly this way.

`spikes/life/life.mojo` is Conway's Life with mouse drawing, pause and single step, and cells coloured by age so you can see a pattern's structure rather than a flat mask. Six hundred lines, and the only non-Cocoa part is the simulation.

`spikes/playground/playground.mojo` is a Mojo editor and runner written in Mojo — a thousand lines, a split view, syntax highlighting, and a child process.

`spikes/mandelbrot/mandelbrot.mojo` draws through a `CAMetalLayer`. It is the one example that depends on the GPU stack, which on Apple Silicon is not finished; treat it as a reading example rather

than a running one.

Debugging, honestly

There is no source-level debugging here yet. What you have is `print`, `respondToSelector:` during bring-up, and the compile-time checks doing more work than they would in most languages.

The three failure modes worth recognising:

A window appears but ignores the keyboard: `acceptsFirstResponder` is missing or returns `False`.

A window appears but cannot be focused and has no Dock icon: `setActivationPolicy:` was not called.

A crash inside `objc_msgSend` with a plausible-looking receiver: an object was released while Cocoa still held it. Look for an `ObjCRef` that went out of scope, or a `new_instance` result that was never retained.

The first two are configuration. The third is the one the compile-time checks cannot reach, which is why chapter 4 spends so long on it.

7. Concurrency and blocks

Grand Central Dispatch is the concurrency story for a Cocoa app: UI work belongs to the main queue and everything else hops between queues. It is a C API in libSystem, so there is nothing to link.

The reason it lands cleanly here is a coincidence of contracts. Every GCD operation exists in two forms — a block form, and an `_f` form taking a bare C function pointer plus a context word — and **the `_f` form is exactly the revived fn**: thin, non-raising, C ABI. So most of `std.objc.dispatch` is direct calls with no adaptation layer at all.

```
from std.objc.dispatch import (
    Semaphore, async_f, global_queue, main_queue, sync_f, with_block,
)
```

Queues

```
var q = global_queue()      # the default-priority concurrent queue
var m = main_queue()       # where UI work belongs
```

`main_queue()` is worth a note: the main queue is not a function in C but a global, `_dispatch_main_q`, and the `dispatch_get_main_queue()` macro takes its address. The library references it the same way it references the `msg_send` stubs — as a link-time symbol.

Dispatching an fn

```
fn set_flag(ctx: P) -> None:
    named_global["app.flag", Int]()[] = 42

sync_f(q, ctx, set_flag)    # runs before returning
async_f(q, ctx, set_flag)   # returns immediately
```

The context word is how you get data to the work function, because an `fn` has no closure. In practice you will often reach for `named_global` instead, the same way Cocoa callbacks do — see [Where callback state lives](#).

`Pointer` is non-nullable, so when the work function ignores its context you still have to hand it a real address rather than null. Any stable one will do.

Waiting: Semaphore

```
var sem = Semaphore()
var ctx = P(unsafe_from_address=sem._sem)

async_f(q, ctx, add_and_signal)
async_f(q, ctx, add_and_signal)
sem.wait()
sem.wait()
```

One `wait()` per expected signal. This is the rendezvous the dispatch spike uses to prove three concurrent `async_f` calls all ran.

Blocks

Plenty of modern Cocoa is block-only, and blocks have their own ABI — isa, flags, invoke pointer, descriptor, copy and dispose helpers. That sounds like a lot of machinery to build.

It is not, because of the correspondence the design turns on: **a thin fn is exactly a global block**. No captures means `_NSConcreteGlobalBlock` and no copy/dispose helpers at all, so the library can build the 32-byte block literal around any `fn` on the stack.

```
fn block_work() -> None:
    var n = named_global["app.count", Int]()
    n[] = n[] + 1

with_block[block_work](q, wait=True)      # sync: no copy needed
with_block[block_work](q, wait=False)     # async: the runtime Block_copy's it
```

The `wait=True` path never escapes the frame, so the stack literal is enough. The `wait=False` path does escape, and dispatch's own `Block_copy` memmoves the 32 bytes off your frame — safe precisely because there are no captures to deep-copy and the descriptor is immortal.

What is not here yet

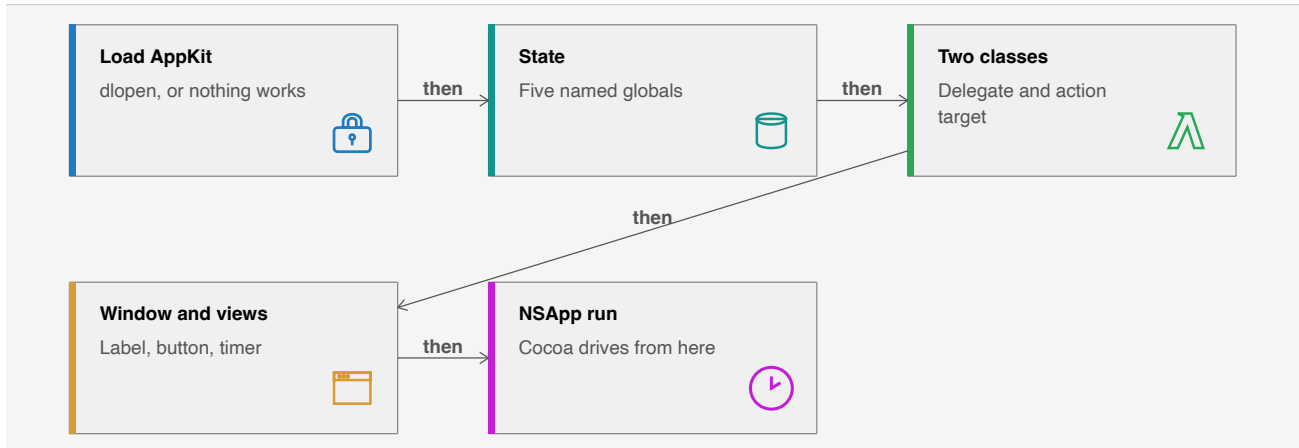
Capturing closures as heap blocks. That needs synthesized copy and dispose helpers riding the existing closure emitter, and it is explicitly a later phase. If an API demands a block that captures, you are outside what the library covers today.

The practical consequence is the one you have already met everywhere else in this guide: state that a callback needs must live somewhere reachable without a closure. `named_global` is the answer here too.

8. A demo, walked through

This chapter reads one complete program line by line: `spikes/playground/p0_window.mojo` in the fork. It is 225 lines, it puts a real window on screen with a button, a label and a timer, and every callback in it is Mojo. It is also the program the fork converted to the cocoa-mojo surface, so it shows `fn` and `let` doing their jobs in a real setting rather than in a test.

Everything below is quoted from the source. Nothing here has been simplified.



The header

```
from std.objc import (
    load_framework, ObjCClass, ObjCObject, msg_send, nsstring,
    autoreleasepool, ObjCClassBuilder, IMP1, IMP1Bool,
    new_instance, named_global, sel,
)
from std.memory import OpaquePointer
from std.os import getenv

comptime P = OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin]
```

`load_framework` leads the import list for a reason we will get to in ten lines. `P` is the abbreviation every CocoaMojo file makes for the raw pointer type that crosses into Objective-C.

Geometry, checked

```
@fieldwise_init
struct CGPoint(Copyable, Movable):
    var x: Float64
    var y: Float64
```

`CGSize` and `CGRect` follow the same shape. In a program you intend to keep, add the layout assertions from [chapter 3](#) — this demo omits them, and that is the one shortcut in it worth not copying.

State the callbacks can reach

```
comptime clicks = named_global["p0.clicks", Int]
comptime ticks = named_global["p0.ticks", Int]
comptime label_addr = named_global["p0.label", Int]
comptime window_addr = named_global["p0.window", Int]
comptime autoclose = named_global["p0.autoclose", Int]
```

Five named process globals, zero until `main` sets them. This is the answer to the constraint that runs through the whole guide: a Cocoa callback is a bare C function pointer and gets no closure, so anything it needs must be reachable by name.

Note the naming discipline — every key is prefixed `p0`. Globals are deduplicated by name across the whole program, so a bare `"count"` is an invitation to collide with someone else's.

A helper that is not a callback

```
def set_label(text: String):
  with autoreleasepool():
    let label = ObjCObject(label_addr())
    _ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSTextField", "setStringValue:"](
      label, nsstring(text).ptr()
    )
```

`def`, not `fn` — Cocoa never calls this, Mojo does. It gets its own autorelease pool because `nsstring` produces an autoreleased object and this is called from timer ticks; without the pool those accumulate until the run loop drains, which on a 0.1-second timer is a slow leak.

`let label` because the binding is written once and only sent messages.

The callbacks

```
fn did_finish_launching(self_: P, cmd: P, note: P):
  print("delegate: applicationDidFinishLaunching: (Cocoa -> Mojo)")

fn should_terminate_after_last_window(self_: P, cmd: P, app: P) -> Bool:
  return True

fn button_clicked(self_: P, cmd: P, sender: P):
  clicks()[ ] += 1
  print("action: buttonClicked: (Cocoa -> Mojo), clicks =", clicks()[ ])
  set_label(String("Clicked ") + String(clicks()[ ]) + " times")
```

Five of these, all `fn`. Before the conversion each carried the `def ... abi("C")` costume; now the keyword states the contract, and a callback that tried to `raise` would fail at its own definition instead of crashing inside AppKit's event loop.

`should_terminate_after_last_window` returning `True` is what makes `[NSApp run]` ever finish — closing the window ends the app.

The `self_: P, cmd: P` prefix is still hand-written. The design proposes a trampoline that injects `_cmd`; it is not implemented, so every callback still declares all three.

```
fn timer_tick(self_: P, cmd: P, timer: P):
    ticks()[] += 1
    set_label(...)
    let limit = autoclose()[]
    if limit > 0 and ticks()[] >= limit:
        let win = ObjCObject(window_addr()[])
        _ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "performClose:"](win, win.ptr())
```

The autoclose path is what makes the demo testable unattended: set `P0_AUTOCLOSE_TICKS=N` and the whole lifecycle — launch, ticks, close, terminate — runs without a human.

main, in order

Load AppKit before anything else

```
def main() raises:
    if not load_framework["AppKit"]():
        raise Error("could not load AppKit")
```

This is the line the fork learned the hard way. In a `mojo run` process nothing linked AppKit, so `ObjCClass.lookup["NSApplication"]()` returns nil and every message to nil silently does nothing. The program starts, prints nothing unusual, and exits without a window.

The application object

```
with autoreleasepool():
    let NSApplication = ObjCClass.lookup["NSApplication"]()
    let app = msg_send[
        ObjCObject, "NSApplication", "sharedApplication", is_class=True
    ](NSApplication.as_object())
    _ = msg_send[Bool, "NSApplication", "setActivationPolicy:"](app, Int(0))
```

`0` is `NSApplicationActivationPolicyRegular` — the difference between an application with a Dock icon and menu bar, and a process that puts up a window nobody can focus.

Two classes, built at runtime

```
var db = ObjCClassBuilder("PlaygroundAppDelegate")
db.add_method["applicationDidFinishLaunching:"](did_finish_launching)
db.add_method["applicationShouldTerminateAfterLastWindowClosed:"](
    should_terminate_after_last_window
)
db.add_method["applicationWillTerminate:"](will_terminate)
```

```
let delegate = new_instance(db^.register())
```

Three real AppKit selectors, so no encodings are written — the database supplies them. `db` stays `var` because `add_method` mutates it; `delegate` is `let`.

```
var ab = ObjCClassBuilder("PlaygroundActions")
ab.add_method["buttonClicked:", encoding="v@:@"](button_clicked)
ab.add_method["timerTick:", encoding="v@:@"](timer_tick)
let actions = new_instance(ab^.register())
```

These two selectors are invented, so the SDK has never heard of them and the encoding must be given. `v@:@` reads: returns void, then `self`, then `_cmd`, then one object argument.

The window

```
var win = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSWindow", "alloc", is_class=True](
    NSWindow.as_object()
)
win = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSWindow",
    "initWithContentRect:styleMask:backing:defer:",
](
    win,
    CGRect(CGPoint(200.0, 200.0), CGSize(420.0, 160.0)),
    Int(15), Int(2), Bool(False),
)
```

`win` is one of the few `var` bindings left, because `alloc` and `init` are two steps and the second rebinds it. The `15` is a style mask and the `2` is `NSBackingStoreBuffered`; both should be `cocoa_kb_enum_value` lookups, and this is the second shortcut in the demo worth not copying.

Label, button, timer

```
let label = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSTextField", "labelWithString:", is_class=True
](NSTextField.as_object(), nsstring(String("waiting...")).ptr())
label_addr()[0] = label.addr()
_ = msg_send[ObjCObject, "NSView", "addSubview:"](content, label.ptr())
```

The label's address goes into a global so `set_label` can reach it from a callback. This is the pattern in miniature: Cocoa owns the object, a global holds the address, and the callback goes through the global.

```
let button = msg_send[
    ObjCObject, "NSButton", "buttonWithTitle:target:action:",
    is_class=True,
](
    NSButton.as_object(),
    nsstring(String("Click me (Mojo)")).ptr(),
    actions.ptr(),
    sel["buttonClicked:"]().ptr(),
)
```

```
)
```

`sel["buttonClicked:"]()` is the one place a selector is needed as a value rather than as a `msg_send` parameter — target/action wants the `SEL` itself.

```
_ = msg_send[
    NSObject, "NSTimer",
    "scheduledTimerWithTimeInterval:target:selector:userInfo:repeats:",
    is_class=True,
](
    NSTimer.as_object(), Float64(0.1), actions.ptr(),
    sel["timerTick:"]().ptr(), actions.ptr(), Bool(True),
)
```

Five arguments, and `msg_send` counted the colons to check you passed five. Note `Float64(0.1)` rather than `0.1` — the interval travels in a float register, and the register-file check would have caught an integer literal here.

Into the run loop

```
print("entering [NSApp run]")
let app2 = msg_send[
    NSObject, "NSApplication", "sharedApplication", is_class=True
](ObjCClass.lookup["NSApplication"]().as_object())
_ = msg_send[NSObject, "NSApplication", "run"](app2)
```

Outside the `with` block, so the setup pool drains before the loop starts; the loop maintains its own pools per event cycle. `app` was bound inside the block that has now ended, hence `app2`.

`run` does not return. `-terminate:` exits the process after `applicationWillTerminate:` has run, which is where the demo prints its verdict.

What the conversion changed

The fork's own summary of this file: *five callbacks lose their def ... abi("C") costume and become what they are — fn, foreign-callable by keyword. Sixteen never-reassigned Cocoa bindings become let.*

Behaviour is identical. What changed is that two contracts the compiler could not previously see — this function is callable from C, this binding is never rebound — are now stated in the source and enforced.

A caveat on running it

Windowed behaviour beyond this program's baseline could not be exercised from the fork's own shell, and that limitation predates the conversion. What is verified is that it compiles, that the sixteen-check suite passes, and that `p0_window` reaches `[NSApp run]` with output unchanged from before. Treat the window itself as reported rather than demonstrated.

CocoaMojo Reference Manual

Look-up material, organised by what you are trying to find. If you are learning rather than checking, start with the [Programmer's Guide](#).

Section	Contents
1. Language reference	The dialect this frozen compiler accepts: keywords, conventions, declarations, and a complete list of what was removed
2. std.objc	Every exported type and function, with signatures
3. cocoakb queries	Every compile-time metadata query, its parameters and its result
4. Diagnostics	The compile errors this layer produces, what each means, and how to fix it

Version

Everything here describes the compiler at the fork point of [MojoCocoa](#), Mojo 1.1.0. The fork does not track upstream, so this reference does not go stale in the usual way — it describes one compiler that does not change.

Facts were taken from the source tree: `mojo/stdlib/std/objc/`, `mojo/stdlib/std/sys/_cocoakb.mojo`, `KGEN/lib/MojoParser/`, and the verification spikes under `spikes/`.

Notation

Parameters appear in square brackets and are resolved at compile time. Arguments appear in parentheses. A parameter with `= value` is defaulted.

```
def msg_send[
  R: AnyType,
  cls: StaticString,
  selector: StaticString,
  is_class: Bool = False,
  *Ts: AnyType,
](obj: ObjCObject, *args: *Ts) -> R
```

Throughout, `P` abbreviates `OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin]`, following the convention used in the standard library itself.

1. Language reference

The dialect accepted by this frozen compiler. Where it differs from published Mojo documentation, this document describes the compiler.

Declarations

Functions

Two keywords, with different contracts.

```
def name(arg: T, ...) -> R:           # ordinary Mojo function
def name(arg: T) raises -> R:
def name[param: T](arg: T) -> R:

fn name(a: P, b: P) -> Bool:          # foreign-callable: thin, C ABI, non-raising
```

`raises` marks a `def` that can raise. `abi("C")` on a `def` gives the C calling convention and belongs before the return arrow; `fn` implies it.

fn — the foreign-callable function. Thin (no captures), non-raising, C ABI, all parameter and return types ABI-classifiable. Exactly the Objective-C `IMP` contract. Callable from Mojo as an ordinary function. May not be marked `raises` or `async`.

Bindings

```
var x = expr           # mutable binding
let x = expr           # immutable binding, function body only
comptime X = expr      # compile-time binding
```

`let` is immutable in the *binding*, not the object: `let win = ...` still permits `setTitle:`. It is general — it applies to values as well as reference-counted objects. Ownership semantics for Cocoa objects live in `ObjCRef`, not in the keyword. There is no field or file-scope `let`.

Function types

```
fn(T1, T2, /) -> R           # sugar for the line below
def(T1, T2, /) thin abi("C") -> R
def[w: Int](Int) thin -> None where (w > 0, "width must be positive")
```

`/` ends the positional-only parameters. `thin` means no captured context. A `thin` function type may carry trailing `where` clauses constraining the parameters it declares; the clause binds to the innermost function type, so a declaration-level `where` after a function-type result needs that result parenthesised:

```
def make[n: Int]() -> (def() thin -> None) where n > 0: ...
```

Binding a constrained function to a function type that declares no matching `where` clause is an error. Passing an unconstrained function where a constrained type is expected is allowed and free.

Compile-time bindings

```
comptime NAME = expression
comptime Alias = SomeType[Param]
```

`alias` still parses but is deprecated: `'alias' is deprecated; use 'comptime'`.

Compile-time control flow

```
comptime if cond:
    ...
else:
    ...

comptime for i in range(n):
    ...

comptime assert condition, "message"
```

`@parameter if` and `@parameter for` still parse but are deprecated. The `@parameter` decorator on parametric closures is now `@__parameter`.

Structs

```
@fieldwise_init
struct Name(Trait1, Trait2):
    var field: T

    def __init__(out self, ...):
    def method(self) -> T:
    def mutator(mut self):
    def consume(deinit self) -> T:
    def __deinit__(deinit self):
```

Struct parameters are declared in brackets after the name:

```
struct ObjCClassBuilder[superclass: StaticString = "NSObject"]:
```

`__new__` is not supported on structs; use `__init__`.

Argument conventions

Convention	Meaning
<i>(omitted)</i>	Immutable borrow. The default.

mut	Mutable borrow.
out	Uninitialised result the callee must initialise.
var	By value; callee owns it.
deinit	Consumes the value, ending its lifetime.

inout, borrowed and owned do not exist.

The transfer sigil `^` moves a value into a consuming position:

```
var cls = builder^.register()
```

Origins

Spelling	Removed alias
ImmOrigin	ImmutOrigin
ImmUnsafeAnyOrigin	ImmutUnsafeAnyOrigin
ImmStaticOrigin	StaticConstantOrigin
UntrackedOrigin	ExternalOrigin
MutUntrackedOrigin	MutExternalOrigin
ImmUntrackedOrigin	ImmutUntrackedOrigin, ImmutExternalOrigin

Also in use: `MutAnyOrigin`, `MutOrigin`.

Pointers

`Pointer[T, Origin]` is the type. `OpaquePointer[Origin]` is the untyped one. `UnsafePointer` exists but is deprecated in favour of `Pointer`.

Removed aliases: `MutUnsafePointer`, `ImmUnsafePointer`, `ImmutUnsafePointer`, `ImmutOpaquePointer`, `ImmutPointer`, `OptionalUnsafePointer`. Use `MutPointer`, `ImmPointer`, `ImmOpaquePointer`, `OptionalPointer`.

Construction and use:

```
Pointer[UInt8, MutUntrackedOrigin](unsafe_from_address=addr)
OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin](unsafe_from_address=addr)
p[]                                # dereference
Pointer(to=value).unsafe_bitcast[T]()
p.bitcast[T]()
```

Renamed methods: `unsafe_as_noalias()`, `unsafe_deinit_pointee()`, `unsafe_deinit_pointee_with()`, `unsafe_write()`, `unsafe_write_move_from()`. `Pointer.type` is now `Pointer.T`.

Renamed free functions: `unsafe_memcpy`, `unsafe_memset`, `unsafe_memset_zero`, `unsafe_uninit_move_n`, `unsafe_uninit_copy_n`, `unsafe_destroy_n`, `unsafe_memcmp`.

Traits in common use

`AnyType`, `Copyable`, `Movable`, `Deinitable`, `TrivialRegisterPassable`.

`ImplicitlyDestructible` and `ImplicitlyDeletable` were renamed to `Deinitable`.

`@explicit_destroy` is no longer required. The `register_passable` and `escaping` function effects are no longer supported.

Decorators

`@fieldwise_init`, `@always_inline`, `@staticmethod`, `@export("name")`, `@deprecated(...)`, `@__parameter`.

MLIR escape hatches

Used by the standard library where no surface syntax exists:

```
__mlir_op.`pop.global_alloc`[...]()
__mlir_op.`pop.extern_ptr_symbol`[...]()
__mlir_attr[`#kgen.param.expr<...>`]
```

These are internal, carry no stability guarantee, and are documented here only so that reading the standard library is possible.

Modules

Directories may have namespace semantics: one directory name may resolve across distinct locations on disk that share the name.

Importing same-named functions from different modules to form one overload set is an error. Intra-package access without an explicit `import` is an error.

`.mojopkg` is gone; the package format is `.mojoc`.

Removed library APIs

Removed	Replacement
<code>InlineArray</code>	<code>Array</code>
<code>SIMD.size</code> , <code>Array.size</code> , <code>TypeList.size</code> , <code>SIMDSize</code>	<code>length</code> , <code>SIMDLength</code>
<code>String.as_string_slice()</code>	<code>StringSpan(s)</code>
<code>String.set_byte_length()</code>	<i>(internal, none)</i>

<code>as_immutable(), get_immutable()</code>	<code>as_imm()</code>
<code>ImmutSpan</code>	<code>ImmSpan</code>
<code>ConditionalType,</code> <code>std.utils.type_functions</code>	<code>T if cond else U</code>
<code>trait_downcast()</code>	<code>conforms_to(...)</code> in <code>where</code> or <code>comptime assert</code>
<code>memcmp</code>	<code>unsafe_memcmp</code>
<code>List.steal_data(),</code> <code>OwnedPointer.steal_data()</code>	<code>unsafe_take_allocation()</code>
<code>OwnedPointer.take()</code>	<code>into_inner()</code>
<code>Variant.take(), Variant.unsafe_take()</code>	<code>unwrap(), unsafe_unwrap()</code>
<code>b64decode(validate=...)</code>	always validates; drop the parameter
<code>std.gpu.profiler, ProfileBlock</code>	<code>perf_counter_ns()</code> , external profiler
<code>benchmark.run[func]()</code>	<code>run(f)</code>
<code>AnyCoroutine, Coroutine,</code> <code>RaisingCoroutine</code>	<i>(unnameable; async def still works)</i>
async task API in <code>std.runtime.asyncrt</code>	<code>initialize_runtime(), parallelism_level()</code> from <code>std.runtime</code>

2.std.objc

The complete exported surface. Throughout, `P` abbreviates `OpaquePointer[MutUntrackedOrigin]`.

```
from std.objc import (
    ObjCClass, ObjCObject, SEL, sel, msg_send, send, autoreleasepool,
    load_framework,
    ObjCRef, ObjCWeakRef,
    NSString, nsstring, extern_object, ns_to_string,
    msg_send_raising, msg_send_raising_check,
    ObjCClassBuilder, IMP0, IMP1, IMP0Bool, IMP1Bool, IMP2,
    new_instance, named_global, sel_dynamic,
)

# GCD lives in its own module
from std.objc.dispatch import (
    Semaphore, async_f, global_queue, main_queue, sync_f, with_block,
)
```

Runtime handles

SEL

A registered Objective-C selector — an interned string pointer.

Member	Signature
<code>ptr</code>	<code>def ptr(self) -> P</code>

Conforms to `TrivialRegisterPassable`.

ObjCClass

A handle on a class object.

Member	Signature
<code>lookup</code>	<code>@staticmethod def lookup[name: StaticString]() -> ObjCClass</code>
<code>is_nil</code>	<code>def is_nil(self) -> Bool</code>
<code>as_object</code>	<code>def as_object(self) -> ObjCObject</code>

`lookup` calls `objc_getClass`. A nil result means the framework is not loaded.

ObjCObject

A borrowed `id`.

Member	Signature

is_nil	def is_nil(self) -> Bool
addr	def addr(self) -> Int
ptr	def ptr(self) -> P

Construct directly from an address with `ObjCObject(Int(raw_pointer))`.

Selectors

sel

```
def sel[name: StaticString]() -> SEL
```

Registers the selector once and caches the result in a per-selector global slot, deduplicated by name in the KGEN lowering. After the first send the cost is one load and a null check.

sel_dynamic

```
def sel_dynamic(name: StaticString) -> P
```

Registers a selector by name at run time, returning the raw pointer. Accepts custom selectors the SDK does not know. Use when calling `class_addMethod` directly.

Message sending

msg_send

```
def msg_send[
  R: AnyType,
  cls: StaticString,
  selector: StaticString,
  is_class: Bool = False,
  *Ts: AnyType,
](obj: ObjCObject, *args: *Ts) -> R
```

Sends `selector` to `obj`, returning `R`.

Parameter	Meaning
R	Return type; must be register-passable
cls	Class the selector is looked up on; inheritance-resolved
selector	The selector, colons included
is_class	True for a + method
Ts	Argument types, inferred

Compile-time checks: the selector must exist on `cls` or a superclass; the argument count must equal the selector's declared count; each argument must be in the register file the ABI expects, for the cases that can be determined certainly; and the `@encode` signature must be modelable.

send

```
def send[R: AnyType, selector: StaticString, *Ts: AnyType](
  obj: ObjCObject, *args: *Ts
) -> R
```

Sends to a **protocol-typed** receiver whose concrete class is unknown at compile time — every Metal object, every delegate. The dispatch stub and argument classes come from the database keyed by selector alone.

Argument count and register-file checks still apply. Receiver-class verification does not.

Ownership

ObjCRef

An owning handle on one +1 reference. Conforms to `Movable`; deliberately not implicitly `Copyable`.

Member	Signature	Notes
init	<code>def __init__(out self, *, adopt: ObjCObject)</code>	Takes ownership of an object already at +1
init	<code>def __init__(out self, *, retain: ObjCObject)</code>	Adds a +1 to a borrowed object
copy	<code>def copy(self) -> Self</code>	Explicit retain
object	<code>def object(self) -> ObjCObject</code>	Borrowed handle, valid for this ref's lifetime
is_nil	<code>def is_nil(self) -> Bool</code>	
autorelease	<code>def autorelease(deinit self) -> ObjCObject</code>	Hands to the current pool; consumes the ref
deinit	<code>def __deinit__(deinit self)</code>	Releases if not nil

Use `adopt=` after `alloc`, `new`, `copy`, `mutableCopy`; `retain=` otherwise.

Backed by the ARC entry points `objc_retain`, `objc_release`, `objc_autorelease`, so it interoperates with ARC code.

autoreleasepool

A scoped pool.

```
with autoreleasepool():
```

...

Pushes on `__enter__`, pops on `__exit__`, and guards against a double pop — popping a token twice corrupts the pool page.

Foundation

NSString

A leak-safe owning wrapper. Conforms to `Movable`.

Member	Signature
init	<code>def __init__(out self, *, adopt: ObjCObject)</code>
init	<code>def __init__(out self, text: String)</code>
object	<code>def object(self) -> ObjCObject</code>
length	<code>def length(self) -> Int</code>
to_string	<code>def to_string(self) -> String</code>
equals	<code>def equals(self, other: NSString) -> Bool</code>
appending	<code>def appending(self, other: NSString) -> NSString</code>

`length` is UTF-16 code units, matching `-[NSString length]`.

nsstring

```
def nsstring(s: String) -> ObjCObject
```

An **autoreleased** `NSString`. For handing to AppKit setters, which retain. Use inside an autorelease pool.

extern_object

```
def extern_object[name: StaticString]() -> ObjCObject
```

The object held in an extern Cocoa constant, such as `NSForegroundColorAttributeName`. These are globals whose address the linker resolves, not compile-time values; this takes a link-time reference to the data symbol and loads the pointer out of it.

Defining classes

IMP type aliases

Alias	Signature
IMP0	fn(P, P, /) -> None
IMP1	fn(P, P, P, /) -> None
IMP0Bool	fn(P, P, /) -> Bool
IMP1Bool	fn(P, P, P, /) -> Bool
IMP2	fn(P, P, P, P, /) -> None

The first two arguments are always `self` and `_cmd`.

ObjCClassBuilder

```
struct ObjCClassBuilder[superclass: StaticString = "NSObject"]
```

Member	Signature
init	def __init__(out self, name: String)
add_method	def add_method(selector: StaticString, encoding: StaticString = "")(mut self, imp: IMPn)
register	def register(deinit self) -> ObjCClass

`add_method` is overloaded across the five IMP shapes. When `encoding` is omitted the SDK's `@encode` for the selector is used, with frame offsets stripped; an unknown selector with no `encoding` is a compile error.

`register` consumes the builder, so call it as `builder^.register()`.

new_instance

```
def new_instance(cls: ObjCClass) -> ObjCObject
```

`+ [cls new]` — an owned (+1) instance. Retain it explicitly if it must outlive the enclosing scope while Cocoa holds a bare pointer to it.

named_global

```
def named_global[name: StaticString, T: AnyType]() -> Pointer[T, MutUntrackedOrigin]
```

A zero-initialised process global of type `T`, shared by name across every call site, because KGEN deduplicates the global. The standard answer to callbacks having no closure.

```
comptime g_running = named_global["life.running", Int]
g_running()[0] = 1
```

Frameworks

load_framework

```
def load_framework[name: StaticString]() -> Bool
```

dlopen of `/System/Library/Frameworks/<name>.framework/<name>` with `RTLD_NOW`. Returns whether the handle is non-null. Idempotent and cheap after the first call.

Foundation arrives in every process; AppKit does not unless the binary linked it, which a `mojo run` process did not. Without this, `ObjCClass.lookup` for an AppKit class returns nil and every message to it silently no-ops.

Errors

msg_send_raising

```
def msg_send_raising[
  cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString,
  T0: AnyType, ..., is_class: Bool = False,
](obj: ObjCObject, a0: T0, ...) raises -> ObjCObject
```

Sends an object-returning `...error:` selector and raises when the result is nil. **The trailing error argument is created and appended by the wrapper — pass the message arguments without it.**

msg_send_raising_check

```
def msg_send_raising_check[
  cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString,
  T0: AnyType, ..., is_class: Bool = False,
](obj: ObjCObject, a0: T0, ...) raises
```

The `BOOL` convention: raises when the result is `NO`. Returns nothing. Same error-slot handling.

Both are declared at explicit arities up to five leading arguments, because nothing may follow an unpacked `*args`. The raised `Error` carries the `NSError`'s `localizedDescription`, domain and code, copied into a Mojo `String`. An API that returns failure without writing an error produces a message saying exactly that.

Weak references

ObjCWeakRef

A zeroing weak reference. Conforms to `Movable`.

Member	Signature	Notes
init	def __init__(out self, target: ObjCObject)	Registers via objc_initWeak; a nil target is legal
load	def load(self) -> ObjCRef	The object at +1 if alive, else a nil ObjCRef
copy	def copy(self) -> Self	An independent registration
deinit	def __deinit__(deinit self)	objc_destroyWeak plus free

The registration slot is heap-allocated — one pointer-sized `malloc` per weak reference — because the runtime tracks weak references by the *address of the slot* and Mojo values move. A struct field would leave the runtime pointing into a dead frame after any move.

`load()` goes through `objc_loadWeakRetained` and therefore returns an owned reference, so the object cannot be deallocated between the nil-check and the use.

Use this wherever Cocoa expects weakness — delegates and observer targets — because an `ObjCRef` there is a retain cycle.

Strings, the other direction

`ns_to_string`

```
def ns_to_string(s: ObjCObject) -> String
```

`NSString` to Mojo `String`, by copy, UTF-8. The result does not depend on the pool owning the `NSString`.

`std.objc.dispatch`

Grand Central Dispatch. Imported directly, not re-exported from `std.objc`.

Name	Signature	Notes
DispatchFn	fn(_RawPtr) -> None	The work-function contract
global_queue	def global_queue() -> _RawPtr	Default-priority concurrent queue
main_queue	def main_queue() -> _RawPtr	<code>&_dispatch_main_q</code> , as the C macro takes it
sync_f	def sync_f(queue, context, work: DispatchFn)	Runs before returning
async_f	def async_f(queue, context, work: DispatchFn)	Returns immediately
Semaphore	struct Semaphore(Movable)	<code>.wait()</code> ; one wait per expected signal
with_block	def with_block[work: fn() -> None](queue, *, wait: Bool)	Builds a real ObjC block around an fn

`with_block` works because a thin `fn` is exactly a global block — `_NSConcreteGlobalBlock`, no captures, so no copy/dispose helpers. The `wait=True` path uses a stack literal; `wait=False` lets the runtime `Block_copy` the 32 bytes off the frame.

Capturing closures as heap blocks are not implemented.

Method type encodings

The strings `class_addMethod` expects, as returned by the database with frame offsets stripped.

Encoding	Meaning
<code>v@:</code>	<code>void method(id self, SEL _cmd)</code>
<code>v@:@</code>	<code>void method(id self, SEL _cmd, id arg)</code>
<code>c@:</code>	<code>BOOL method(id self, SEL _cmd)</code>
<code>c@:@</code>	<code>BOOL method(id self, SEL _cmd, id arg)</code>
<code>@@:</code>	<code>id method(id self, SEL _cmd)</code>

Single-character type codes: `v` void, `c` `BOOL` (a signed char), `@` object, `:` selector, `i` int, `q` long long, `Q` unsigned long long, `d` double, `f` float, `*` C string, `^` pointer to.

`BOOL` is `c`, not `B`. This is the encoding most often written wrongly by hand.

3. cocoakb queries

Compile-time queries against `cocoa.sqlite`. Every one resolves to a constant before code generation, so a name the metadata does not know is a compile error rather than a wrong answer.

```
from std.sys._cocoakb import cocoakb_struct_size, cocoakb_field_offset
```

The module is underscore-prefixed because it is compiler-adjacent, not because it is off limits — the verification spikes import it directly.

Layout

cocoakb_struct_size

```
def cocoakb_struct_size[name: StaticString]() -> Int
```

Size in bytes of a Cocoa struct. `name` is spelled as the runtime spells it, for example `"CGRect"`.

cocoakb_struct_align

```
def cocoakb_struct_align[name: StaticString]() -> Int
```

Alignment in bytes.

cocoakb_field_offset

```
def cocoakb_field_offset[type_name: StaticString, field: StaticString]() -> Int
```

Byte offset of a field within a struct. This is what makes a declaration checkable rather than merely plausible.

```
comptime assert sizeof[CGRect]() == cocoakb_struct_size["CGRect"]()
comptime assert cocoakb_field_offset["CGRect", "size"]() == 16
```

Constants

cocoakb_enum_value

```
def cocoakb_enum_value[name: StaticString]() -> Int
```

The value of an enum member, from BridgeSupport. Signed, so a value that must sign-extend as a pointer does behaves correctly, and a flag mask narrowed by the caller keeps its bits either way.

```
comptime assert cocoakb_enum_value["NSUTF8StringEncoding"]() == 4
```

cocoakb_constant_type

```
def cocoakb_constant_type[name: StaticString]() -> StaticString
```

The declared type encoding of an extern-symbol constant, for example "@" for an object. Constants like `NSFontAttributeName` are runtime addresses, not compile-time values; this reports the type, and `extern_object` fetches the value.

Classes and methods

cocoakb_superclass

```
def cocoakb_superclass[name: StaticString]() -> StaticString
```

cocoakb_method_encoding

```
def cocoakb_method_encoding[  
  cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString, is_class: Bool = False  
]() -> StaticString
```

The verbatim `@encode` signature, inheritance-resolved: the lookup walks the superclass chain, so asking `NSMutableString` about `length` finds `NSString`'s definition. Returns the raw form including frame offsets, for example `"Q16@0:8"`.

cocoakb_msgsend_variant

```
def cocoakb_msgsend_variant[  
  cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString, is_class: Bool = False  
]() -> StaticString
```

Which `objc_msgSend` entry point the send must use. Returns `"objc_msgSend"`, `"objc_msgSend_stret"`, or `"objc_msgSend_fpret"`; `"?"` marks a signature the ABI classifier could not model, and callers assert against it.

On arm64 the answer is always `"objc_msgSend"`. AAPCS64 has neither `_stret` nor `_fpret` — an aggregate return travels in `x0–x1`, in `v0–v3` when it is a homogeneous float aggregate, or through the `x8` indirect-result register. The query is retained because its other job — rejecting unmodelable signatures — still matters.

cocoakb_method_ret_class

```
def cocoakb_method_ret_class[
```

```
cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString, is_class: Bool = False
]() -> StaticString
```

The AAPCS64 return classification, in the token vocabulary below.

cocoakb_method_arg_classes

```
def cocoakb_method_arg_classes[
  cls: StaticString, selector: StaticString, is_class: Bool = False
]() -> StaticString
```

Comma-joined classifications of the arguments beyond `self` and `_cmd`. An empty string means the selector takes none; "g" means one; "g,g" two.

Selector-keyed queries

For protocol-typed receivers whose concrete class is unknown at compile time.

cocoakb_selector_variant

```
def cocoakb_selector_variant(selector: StaticString]() -> StaticString
```

The dispatch variant, taken from any class implementing the selector. An empty result or "?" means no class in the metadata implements it.

cocoakb_selector_arg_classes

```
def cocoakb_selector_arg_classes(selector: StaticString]() -> StaticString
```

cocoakb_selector_encoding

```
def cocoakb_selector_encoding(selector: StaticString]() -> StaticString
```

The `@encode` signature by majority across implementing classes, for example "v24@0:8@16". Used by `ObjCClassBuilder` to type a Mojo method when defining a class at run time.

POSIX

The same database describes the C library.

Query	Returns
<code>cocoakb_posix_sig[name]()</code>	The full C type as clang reports it, e.g. "int (const char *, int, ...)"
<code>cocoakb_posix_ret_class[name]()</code>	AAPCS64 return classification

cocoakb_posix_arg_classes[name] ()	AAPCS64 argument classifications
--	----------------------------------

Provenance

cocoakb_db_hash

```
def cocoakb_db_hash() -> StaticString
```

The SHA-256, lowercase hex, of the database this compilation consulted. A binary can record exactly which metadata revision produced it, which is the reproducibility pin and also how you notice a stale database after a macOS update.

The AAPCS64 token vocabulary

These tokens come from `derive_method_abi.py` in CocoaBaseMCP. They are **not** the SysV eightbyte vocabulary, and reading them as if they were puts a homogeneous float aggregate in the wrong register file.

Token	Meaning	Register file
v	void	—
g	general-purpose register	integer
f	scalar float	float, v0–v7
h2, h3, h4	homogeneous float aggregate of k members	float, k consecutive v registers
i1, i2	small integer struct	integer
b	by-value pointer	integer
x	indirect result via x8	—
s	struct	integer
m	memory	—
?	unmodelable; a compile error	—

A value goes in a `v` register when it is a scalar float or a homogeneous float aggregate. Everything else goes in the integer file. Testing whether every byte of a token is `f` would be the SysV reading and would misclassify an HFA.

Worked examples from the verification spike:

Query	Result
cocoakb_method_ret_class["NSString", "length"]()	"g" — one GPR
cocoakb_method_ret_class["NSValue", "rectValue"]()	"h4" — CGRect in v0–v3

cocoakb_method_encoding["NSMutableString", "length"]()
--

"Q16@0:8"

4. Diagnostics

The compile errors this layer produces, what each one means, and what to do. Messages are quoted from the source that emits them.

Language-level

'fn' declares a foreign-callable (C ABI, non-raising) function in cocoa-mojo and may not be marked 'raises'; use 'def' for an ordinary Mojo function

`fn` is the foreign-callable function. The C boundary has no error channel, so a raising `fn` cannot exist. Comes with a FixIt replacing `fn` with `def`.

This is also the migration message: code from the era when `fn` was a general strict function (`fn main() raises`) gets told what changed rather than a bare contract violation.

'fn' declares a foreign-callable function and cannot be 'async'; use 'def'

Same contract, same remedy.

'let' declares an immutable binding inside a function body; use 'var' for a field or module value

`let` has no field or file-scope form. Use `var` there.

Reassigning a let

Rebinding a `let` is a compile error. The object remains mutable — this is about the binding, not the value. See [the language chapter](#).

'alias' is deprecated; use 'comptime'

A warning, not an error. `alias` still parses.

'__new__' is not supported on structs; use '__init__' instead

the 'register_passable' function effect is no longer supported

the 'escaping' function effect is no longer supported

implicit deletion. '@explicit_destroy' is no longer required.

Remove the decorator; implicit deletion is now the default.

std.objc compile-time assertions

These come from `comptime assert` inside `msg_send`, `send` and `ObjCClassBuilder`, so they fire during elaboration and name the problem precisely.

Unknown or unmodelable signature

```
std.objc: 'SELECTOR' on CLASS has an @encode signature the ABI classifier
could not model, so std.objc cannot pick a dispatch stub for it. Call it by
hand with a checked external_call if you know the layout.
```

`cocoa_kb_msgsend_variant` answered `"?"`. Rare, and the escape hatch is the one the message names: call it yourself with `external_call`, having worked out the layout.

Wrong argument count

```
std.objc: 'SELECTOR' on CLASS takes N argument(s), but M were passed.
```

Count the colons in the selector. `stringWithUTF8String:` takes one; `initWithContentRect:styleMask:backing:defer:` takes four. This is the check that prevents reading an unset argument register.

Wrong register file — float where an integer is expected

```
std.objc: argument I of 'SELECTOR' on CLASS is a float, but the ABI expects an
integer/pointer register here. Check the argument type.
```

Wrong register file — integer where a float is expected

```
std.objc: argument I of 'SELECTOR' on CLASS is an integer, but the ABI expects
a float register here. Pass a Float32/Float64.
```

The usual cause is an integer literal where a `CGFloat` is wanted. Write `Float64(0)` rather than `0`. These checks fire only where the classification is certain, so an absence of error is not proof of correctness for struct arguments.

Selector implemented by nothing

```
std.objc: no class in the metadata implements selector 'SELECTOR', so its
dispatch ABI is unknown. Check the selector spelling.
```

From `send`. Either the selector is misspelled, or the framework declaring it was not scanned when the database was built.

Unknown selector encoding when defining a class

Raised by `ObjCClassBuilder.add_method` when `encoding` is omitted and the SDK does not know the selector. Supply it:

```
b.add_method["myCustomAction:", encoding="v@:@"](handler)
```

cocoa kb query failures

A name the database does not contain fails the query itself. The `must_fail.mojo` spike is exactly this:

```
comptime bogus = cocoa kb_struct_size["NSDefinitelyNotAstruct"]()
```

The build fails. It does not return zero, and it does not return a plausible size.

If a name you believe is real fails, work through these in order.

Is the database built? `python3 ../CocoaBaseMCP/build.py`.

Is the compiler pointed at it? `MODULAR_MOJO_MAX_COCOAKB_PATH` must name an existing `cocoa.sqlite`.

Is it stale? Rebuild after a macOS update. `cocoa kb_db_hash()` tells you which revision a compilation used.

Is the spelling the runtime's? The database is built from the live Objective-C runtime and BridgeSupport, so it holds the runtime's names, not a header's typedef.

Runtime failures the compiler cannot catch

Three things remain yours.

A nil class. `ObjCClass.lookup` returns nil when the framework is not loaded. Every subsequent message to it does nothing, silently. Check `is_nil()` once at startup.

Use after the pool drains. An object handed to a pool by `autorelease()` is valid only until that pool exits. Nothing checks this.

An object released while Cocoa still holds it. Typically an `ObjCRef` that went out of scope, or a `new_instance` result never retained, where Cocoa keeps a bare pointer. The symptom is a crash inside `objc_msgSend` with a plausible-looking receiver.

Symptoms with no error at all

Symptom	Cause
Window appears but ignores the keyboard	<code>acceptsFirstResponder</code> missing or returning <code>False</code>
Window cannot be focused, no	<code>setActivationPolicy:</code> not called with <code>0</code>

Dock icon	
Callback never fires	Selector added under a different spelling, or <code>register()</code> never ran
<code>respondsToSelector:</code> returns <code>False</code>	Same as above; check the selector string character by character
Allocator corruption far from any Cocoa call	A <code>List</code> pointer stashed after its last use; allocate outside Mojo instead
<code>autorelease pool</code> page corrupted	A pool token popped twice
Windowed app starts and exits with no window and no message	<code>load_framework["AppKit"]()</code> was not called; every message to the <code>nil</code> class silently no-ops
A crash when assigning into a var declared but not initialised	Pre-existing: assigning into an uninitialised var of a type with <code>__deinit__</code> destroys garbage first. Bind in a helper scope and return instead